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Marketing



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What do our participants have to say?

Here's what some of our participants had to say after attending the Sales and Marketing workshop.



"The marketing segment stood out for me because when I entered the programme that is one thing that my business lacked the most and which I needed the most assistance with. Participating in this workshop now was indeed helpful because it has equipped me with sufficient knowledge to direct the team."

Sindisiwe Hlatshwayo, Shalaw Legal Solutions



"The facilitator was amazing! He had such a practical approach to facilitation. He made the topic engaging and most importantly easy to implement."

Barbara Ayissi, Puzzle of My Life



"For me, the best part of the workshop was connecting with my fellow entrepreneurs and hearing what they are doing in their businesses. The facilitator showed an in depth understanding and a passion for the topic."

Modise Mongane, Thrift Online



"I loved this workshop; the facilitators were awesome and super fun. My key learnings were to always make sure you do my market research, speak to the MAN and ask for their budget."

Jo-andra Greegory, Our Poultry Place

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1. MARKETING: AN OVERVIEW

How is marketing different from sales?

Many people think that sales and marketing are one concept, so intertwined that they cannot easily be separated. In truth, they are two related but very different disciplines, with a common end goal – organizational growth, sustainability and success.

In simple terms we use marketing to find, communicate with, inspire and attract potential supporters, funders, investors, partners and customers. We then apply our sales magic to seal the deal!

Some definitions you should know:

Marketing is the means by which an organization communicates to, connects with, and engages its target audience to convey the value of and ultimately sell its products and services. Since the emergence of digital media, in particular social media and technology innovations, it has increasingly become more about companies building **deeper, more meaningful and lasting** relationships with the people that they want to support or buy their products and services.

Some marketing terms

A **target market** is a group of customers that the business has decided to target with its marketing efforts and ultimately its products. A well-defined target market is the first element to an effective sales and marketing strategy.

Inbound marketing refers to marketing activities that bring visitors in, rather than marketers having to go out to get prospects' attention. Inbound marketing earns the attention of customers, makes the company easy to be found, and draws customers to a contact point such as a website by producing interesting content. (BEES TO HONEY)

Outbound marketing involves all the proactive marketing steps we undertake to communicate with our target market/s, to create awareness of our business and products, and to encourage customer loyalty and repeat business. It includes things like advertising, media and PR, customer surveys, etc.

A **brand** is the identity of a specific product, service, or business. A brand can take many forms, including a name, sign, symbol, colour combination or slogan. Brands should be seen as more than just a logo however. They represent the sum of all valuable qualities of a product or company to the consumer.

The **marketing mix** refers to the set of actions, or tactics, that a company uses to promote its brand or product in the market. It can involve direct marketing actions, e-marketing, social media, brand

"Here's a simple test.

Ask a few people to name a logo they like.

With very few exceptions, people will choose a logo that's associated with a brand they admire. That's because what makes a good logo is a good brand, not the other way around." Seth Godin.

2. UNDERSTANDING THE MARKET

Typically, when starting a business most people are tempted to try to sell to everyone – believing that by including the whole world as a possible customer they will increase the chances of success. Interestingly, the opposite is in fact usually true, and unless you are selling mass consumer goods such as water or electricity, a business that identifies & focuses on a specific target market is more, not less likely to thrive.

Before you decide about the what, where, why and how of your marketing strategy and approach, you need to determine the WHO.

Who are the people, clients, groups, end users or organisations that are most likely to support your products & services? This could be the end users, or the partners you need to reach them.

The starting point for any SE that wants to improve both its sales and marketing success, is to decide who your target market is. Why do you think this is the case

- If you know who you are looking for, you can determine where to find them
- If you know who you are talking to, you can determine what you should be saying
- If you know who you are serving, you can ensure that you meet their

needs Knowing your target market is the starting point – everything else

stems from there:



2.1 The Value Chain

The Value Chain is the journey your product or service takes before it ends up in the hands of the end user. Other players (besides you and the end user) in the Value Chain could include your channel partners - wholesalers, retailers, agents, sector specialists, NPOs, Funders etc.

Example – Typical Production Value Chain



Example – Typical Service Value Chain



The reason these other players are so important is that often without them you will not be able to access certain markets – for example, an international NGO might be able to get your products into a country they are active in, or a health product wholesaler might be able to get your products onto the shelves at Spar, or a property developer might be able to help your environmental consultancy by marketing your services to their clients on a wholesale basis.

Your job is to know what value chain players you need, and to make them aware of your products and services and the value you can bring to their businesses.

People often criticise the 'Middle Man', but the truth is that the Value Chain needs the various links, with each person making their own profit, in order to work. That said, if there are too many 'links' in the chain then your product or service can end up being too expensive when it reaches the end user, leading to failure. So, a streamlined, efficient and effective Value Chain is always best.

Listed below is a table highlighting some different value Chain players and sales channels you may encounter:

VALUE CHAIN PLAYERS
Small Retailers e.g., one-off shops, decor and gift stores, speciality stores
Large Retailers e.g., Woolworths, Spar, Boxer, Pick n Pay
Corporates e.g., ABSA, Old Mutual
Interior Decorators and Architects
Direct Retail e.g., markets and events, e-commerce, your own shop – this category could include international tourists, local tourists, general public etc
Government Procurement Channels – many government departments make use of smaller suppliers for their procurement needs, from catering to corporate gifts & clothing
Tour Operators & Travel Agencies – tour operators often use smaller players such as shuttle service providers, guesthouses and makers of gifts and curios
Hospitality Industry – guest houses, hotels, B&B's
Advertising and Promotional Agencies
Conference & Event Coordinators & Wedding Planners

2.2 Market positioning

Once you have decided who your primary target market/s are, your next step is to position yourself in their minds. What is the perception of your company and your brand that you want to create in relation to competing brands or businesses? This is known as market positioning.

Market positioning refers to the process of establishing the image or identity of your brand, so that your target market perceives it in a certain way.

Some examples:

- A car maker may position itself as an eco-friendly alternative to the rest e.g., Tesla
- A battery maker may position its batteries as the most reliable and long-lasting e.g., Duracell
- A fast-food restaurant chain may position itself as a provider of healthy and nutritious meals e.g., Kauai
- A coffee company may position itself as the place to go for sustainable, socially impactful coffee e.g. I Love Coffee
- A retailer might position itself as the best place to buy clothing at low prices e.g., Mr Price
- A computer company may position itself as offering hip, innovative and user-friendly technology products e.g., Apple

2.3 Leveraging your story

Establishing your market positioning starts with the creation of a fundamental core brand message - a compact statement that declares why the brand matters, what it stands for and how it stands apart from competitors. Often, this is based on the Vision and Mission of your business.

Your marketing message is what grabs your prospect's attention, tells them how you can solve their problem, why they should trust you, and why they should choose to do business with you over and above all other choices they might have. Above all else, it makes your target audience sit up and ... care.

This core message often needs to resonate with potential funders & partners, over and above the actual end users or beneficiaries of the products &/or services.

It's a message that will guide and inform all your other marketing efforts and communications, so you need to get it right.

Remember, you need to think how you want to be POSITIONED in the minds of your target audience when you are creating your core message:

- A firm that wants to differentiate itself in the marketplace may formulate a core message or marketing campaign theme that contrasts itself with the rest of the industry (Avis' "We try harder" comes to mind).
- A firm that wants to position itself as more efficient and customer-facing will choose a core message like Standard Bank's "Simpler. Better. Faster"
- A firm that wants to position itself as at the forefront of innovation would choose a core message such as Apple's "Think Different".

Crafting messages that are concise, easy to understand and tell a coherent story can be a lot trickier than you think. But once you've found your voice, you'll discover that people suddenly do a lot more listening!

So, how do YOU want to be positioned?

2.4 Creating your core message

We are now going to spend a bit of time creating our core message, the one that will be the foundation in terms of how we position our company and our brand in the marketplace.

We need to follow these five steps:

STEP 1 – Identify your target market

The first step starts out by asking, "Who is my target market?" Once you have narrowed this down then it's easier to craft a message to that market.

Describe your target market below. If you have more than one, classify them as Primary (most NB) and Secondary (less NB):

STEP 2 – Identify the problems that your target market experiences

The second step starts by asking, “What problems do my target market/s have and how does this make them feel?”

If you are positioning your message at 3rd Party Funders or Donors, what is the core problem that they are trying to solve, and what challenges do they experience that makes this tough?

Each market experiences its frustrations and pains. The secret to crafting a marketing message that will make your market sit up and listen is to identify their problem and the challenges they feel as a result of that problem. Identifying your market’s pain and challenge tells them that you understand and empathise with them.

What problem does your target market experience? If there are a few, list them all below but try and stay focused on the main ones:

STEP 3 – Present your solution to your market's problem

The third step starts by asking, "What is the solution that I have to offer?"

Present your solution as a simple cure for all the pain and suffering your market is feeling as a result of their problem – **or for the problem they are trying to solve.**

Below, identify all the benefits of your solution and how these benefits will improve the life of your prospect and take away their pain and anguish or anxiety:

STEP 4 – Present the results you've produced for other people in the same situation

The fourth step starts by asking, "What are the results that my solution has produced?"

It's not enough just to tell people you have a solution; you have to prove to them that your solution works.

In this step you'll need to prove your results by giving details of actual problems that were solved and the results that were achieved.

Write down an actual example of an excellent result you produced for one of your clients, funders or partners:

STEP 5 – Explain what makes you different from your competitors

The fifth step starts by asking, "How am I different from my

competitors?" You need to communicate your differences!

Potential clients, partners and customers are looking for you to communicate your differences. And those differences need to have perceived value to them. It needs to be something they care about.

How are you different from your competitors?

Summing it all up and crafting your message

- Read through the work you have done above.
- Circle/isolate key words in each section that jump out at you.
- Craft these words into a short, clear positioning statement for your business.

REMEMBER: The biggest marketing message mistake that companies make is communicating “What-We-Do” instead of “Why-We-Do-It” and ‘What’s-In-It-For-Me.” If these were three radio channels (i.e. WWD vs WWDI & WIIFM), which would you rather listen to?

While you are transmitting on WWD, your prospect is looking for the WWDI and WIIFM station. In order for your message to match your market you need to be broadcasting on WWDI & WIIFM.



3. PUTTING IT INTO PRACTICE

We have spent some time distilling what it is that makes you special above. Now we want to help you put this into practice, so let's start with a story....

Imagine that you live deep in a thick, impenetrable forest. While experimenting with some of the herbs you find growing in the forest, you develop the most amazing product in the world – an anti-aging cream that reverses the ravages of getting old – after a few simple applications, this wonder cream makes the user look at least ten years younger, with no side –effects!!

Clearly, there will be massive demand for such a product all over the world.

Problem is, you are hidden away from civilization deep in this forest. Nobody knows where you are, how to find you or anything about you, your brand, your company, or your product. You are sitting on a potential goldmine, but unless you can spread the word, it is worthless. So what do you need to do?

This is where the marketing function begins ...

3.1 Identify your target market - Activity

When it comes to marketing (and sales!), half the battle is knowing who is most likely to support your business – in other words your target market, as discussed above.

The reason you need to identify a target market is because it makes finding and communicating with your potential customers, as well as designing, pricing, distributing, promoting, positioning and improving your product, service or idea easier, more successful, and more cost-effective.

Your target market analysis should answer the following questions at the very least:

- Is there a gap in the market for my offering? Explain.

- What kinds of customers want my product or service? (age, gender, buying habits)

- What sort of products or services do they want?

- What pricing strategy is suited to this market? (Premium, high, mid, low)

- How does my market procure new goods/services? E.g. internet, direct, RFQs?

- What is the competition offering and how can I be different from them?

Once your initial analysis is complete, it's time to dig a bit deeper. You will find that you have different groups of customers and to ensure your marketing efforts are speaking to all of them, it is worth spending the time to segment them and develop customer personas.

Brands often use segmentation to help understand and target an audience. This means taking into consideration general details about the average customer, such as their demographic, gender, socio-economic status and so on. This information can then be used to develop customer personas. Personas can be one of the most effective ways of bringing this customer segmentation to life.

So, you may be wondering, what exactly are customer personas, and why are they so important?

A customer persona (or buyer persona/user persona) is a fictional character that you make up to represent your ideal customer. It's usually based on market research and any data you've collected from your existing customers.

When creating your buyer or customer persona you should include:

- Customer demographics
- Their age, gender and occupation
- Their behaviour patterns
- Their pain points
- Your customer's motivations and goals
- The value you provide to them

Customer personas are a big help when it comes to building up a strong insight into what your customers are like. A detailed persona will allow you to focus on what parts of your business appeal to your customers. It will help you align your services with what your customers want to see.

With strong customer personas at your fingertips, you will be able to attract more valuable visitors to your social media tribe and website that will more likely convert and become a paying client for your business.

Developing personas require a lot of time, patience, research, and strategy. If you want to construct the perfect persona to represent your target audience, then you need to start by asking yourself some questions.

You need to define exactly who you want to attract to your company, what you have to offer and why.

By being thorough with your analysis you will be able to gather a lot of key details about your target audience. The more details you have about your target market's driving motivations, the more effective your customer personas will be.

The questions you ask about your audience will help you lay the foundation to keep them coming back for more from you

Customer persona questions can include:

- How old are they?
- What do they do for a living?
- How do they spend their money?
- What do they do for fun?
- What other hobbies do they have?
- What keeps them up at night?
- Where do they hang out?
- What do they look for in your type of business?
- How can you give them the perfect solution to their problems?

Answering these questions will help you create a base of what your ideal customer is like. You want to really get to know your target audience so you can understand them as people, as individuals with their own problems, wants and desires. If you can understand them then you can figure out how you can give them what they want.

Also, think about how you can communicate your unique selling points (USP) to your customers. If you can figure out what sort of person your target customers are then you can figure out what makes your company unique to them.

Focus on what each customer persona needs and wants from you and how you can benefit their lives. This will make it easier for you to connect with them and convert them into repeat paying customers.

Now, instead of making content that is specific to you and what you think will look good on your website, your customer personas can help you create content that will inform, engage and entertain your target audience.

Here is an example of a customer persona

Persona 1: Felicia, the Fabulous Fashionista



The Business: Retro Threads – trendy retro fashion accessories

Age:	mid 20ies to early 30ies	Single with no children
Income:	R25 000 – R50 000 p/m	Stylish trend-setter
Location:	Affluent suburbs of Gauteng	Passionate about fashion and shopping
Occupation:	Clothing designer	

Shopping Preference:
online

Social Media Preferences:
Facebook and Instagram

Hobbies:
art, reading and online shopping

Goals:
to find trendy fashion accessories to match her outfits for fashion shows

Benefits of our product:
trendy accessories in a variety of colours and styles to accompany every outfit. We also manufacture bespoke pieces for her.

3.2 Get the word out

The next step is to make your identified target market aware of you and your product or service, as well as the benefit and value it can add to their lives. In our forest example, this may mean having to send out information via carrier pigeon, helicopter or smoke signals ... the desired end result is that you are spreading information and creating awareness and interest in your product or service.

In a normal marketing context, there are many channels we use to get the word out – can you think of a few?

- print media (magazines and newspapers)
- websites and social media
- brochures and flyers
- advertising – print, electronic, outdoor
- spokespeople and brand ambassadors
- promotions – in-store, at events and functions, etc.
- networking and industry events

“We find that marketing works the way the grass grows. You can never see it, but every week you have to cut the lawn.” Andy Travis

Using your core message as a guide, come up with and briefly describe below a marketing

- A radio

- An angle for a media

- Who would your ideal brand ambassador be and

3.3 Build a pathway to your business

Having created some awareness, the next thing you need to do is make it easy for people to find you and more importantly, your product. Clearly, no-one will come and buy your product if it is impossible to get through the thick forest, even if they really want it. So, your job is to **build a pathway** that makes it easy for them.

In our forest context, this would mean getting a bulldozer/machete and clearing a path so that people could easily travel to your door. Maybe you will need to build a helicopter landing pad or develop a chartered transport solution to make it easy for your potential customers to reach you.

In traditional marketing, what does this mean? It means taking steps to make accessing you, your products and services, an easy, pleasant, and hassle-free experience for potential customers. It would involve things like

- **Aligning** with statutory bodies and relevant industry associations so they have your details and can direct interested parties to you e.g. Institute of Architects, Master Builder's Association, agricultural bodies, etc.
- **Effective and visible signage** – for example if you have a shop or a showroom/office, or on your company vehicle, if you have one.
- Being **easily contactable** and keeping details up to date (email, cellphone).
- Making sure you appear in any relevant **industry publications**, such as newsletters, brochures and magazines.
- **Spreading the news** by presenting your product through more than one outlet, in more than one area – this may mean doing trade shows, exhibitions, etc.
- **Registering** on any relevant procurement databases.
- **A professional online presence**, including an up-to-date website, and social media platforms,

if appropriate for your product or service offering.

3.4 Encourage the desired action/s

So now they know about us and can find us - what next?

There are many reasons people engage in marketing initiatives and activities. Very often it is to generate interest and build a pipeline of potential customers that will ultimately help drive sales, but that is not always the main purpose. Sometimes companies use marketing to open a dialogue with their potential target market/s, or to get feedback on a new product or service they are thinking of launching. Sometimes, we just want to learn more about our customers and what they like and dislike, so that we can be more focused in our service offering, product development, packaging, etc. Other times we use marketing to help create an image, or brand for our company that positions us in a certain way, such as being youth-oriented, luxurious, or environmentally conscious, etc.

In our forest example, and many others, a primary desired action is to get people to try and buy your product or service. So your job is to create an environment and a set of circumstances that encourages this action.

Keeping your core positioning in mind, what 3 ways would you choose to “build a path” so that prospective clients are easily able to access your products & services?

- _____
- _____
- _____

It means giving some thought to your customers experience:

- branding and corporate ID – creating a perception in the mind of your clients
- clear, concise service offerings for service-based businesses
- packaging of the product if you are a manufacturer/reseller
- samples and testers
- store/stand layout if you have a retail space or showroom
- office signage, marketing materials
- display and merchandising of your product range/s
- sales unit sizes – small, medium, large, etc.
- in-store information and displays/posters, etc.
- your pricing strategy
- Your online presence and the customer experience of this

Bearing in mind your brand promise, how can you encourage the desired actions in your business context?

- _____
- _____
- _____

3.5 Create customers for life

A final element of marketing is about encouraging customer loyalty. Ideally, we all want customers who not only come back and buy from us time and again, but also speak positively of us to others. This is known as 'word-of-mouth' marketing, and it is one of the most powerful forms of marketing around.

In our forest home, we can encourage customer loyalty by making sure every visitor has a memorable experience and gets more value than they were expecting. Perhaps we can offer free tea or coffee to them after their long journey to find us, or a small gift to take away to remind them of their visit. Maybe we take each of them on a tour of the forest and surrounds, showing them the process of how we came to develop such an amazing product. Free samples and generosity are also never a bad strategy.

In a traditional context, businesses encourage customer loyalty by:

- listening to their customers
- always keeping their promises and being willing to help
- inspiring confidence (good product knowledge)
- treating every customer as an individual
- making it easy for customers to do business with them
- ensuring all physical aspects of the company, as well as its products and services, give a favourable impression
- offering great after-sales service, generous warranties and peace of mind
- genuinely going the extra mile
- always looking to solve problems

With your overriding brand message in mind, what steps do you currently take (or can you take in future) to create customers for life in your business?

- _____

- _____

- _____

4. Telling your business story

There was a time when a company's "About Us" page did not matter quite so much: A short bio, a mission statement and you are done. These days, consumers care more and more about buying locally, supporting independent businesses, and owning products that are made sustainably and responsibly. They want to know the story of what they are buying, who is selling it and what causes it may support. In a business landscape where success hinges on establishing a personal connection with customers and investors, the "About Us" page has become prime real estate.

"A lot of business owners fall in love with their own product and forget that other people need to be romanced by a story. A brand should make you feel something when you say the name. Without context, it's just stuff."

These days, having that "About Us" page that paints a complete picture is more important than ever. In tough economic times when consumers have fewer discretionary funds, they want to feel good spending that money. Whether the story is about sustainability, buying local or being an underdog, we want to feel there's a person behind the company that we're buying into, and that there's a sense of purpose we can relate to.

Good stories open doors. Without one, your business may not get the attention it deserves.

Before crafting your story, think about the following: What is your goal? Make sure you know exactly how you want your audience to act after hearing your story. Do you want them to buy your product or service? Join the company? Invest? Stories can power you toward a goal only if the message is crystal clear.

Let's look at the three basic components of telling your business story in an effective and

compelling way. The three basic storytelling questions:

- **Who** Are You?
- **What** Do You Do?
- **Why** Do You Do It?

These may seem obvious, but the importance of answering all three is still often overlooked. Let's take a look at each of these questions and how to answer them effectively.

Who Are You?

There are several aspects to this:

- Your history and company culture.
- Your people: names, faces, and stories – not just those of the founder(s), but everyone who works with you (up to a point, of course).
- Your vision, philosophy, and values. What would the world look like if it were up to you?
- Your mission and objectives. Now we know what you want the world to look like; what is your commitment to making it head in that direction?

A somewhat paradoxical thing to keep in mind is that this is not really about you, as a person or as a company. Rather, telling people who you are is about **what they can expect from you**, on a personal level. The objective is not to create some Elon Musk-like personality cult. The objective is to make your customers buy into your company's vision and mission, which is crucial for their loyalty. And the way to make them do so is to tell them about it, in a complete and congruent manner, including all the aspects listed above.

What Do You Do?

Your product or service, and the way it improves your customers' lives, needs to be front and centre. In addition, it is important to explain your commitment to your customers. As with talking about who you are, this is about what people can expect from you, but this time on a professional level. Quality assurance, product uniqueness, customer care – you name it.

There are several aspects you could focus on:

- What problem do you want to solve? (Echoing your vision and mission)
- How does your product or service benefit your customer?
- Does your product or service have additional noteworthy impact on the environment or social impact?
- Are you and your team doing any good work in your communities

Tell stories about individuals. *"One death is a tragedy, a million deaths is a statistic" - Joseph Stalin*

Share customer testimonials. Customer referrals are marketing nuggets! Names and faces are much more memorable than numbers and graphs.

Why Do You Do It?

The Why question is the secret sauce that makes all of the above work. Answering this question well is what makes the difference between a congruent and appealing story or looking like your average Corporate Social Responsibility marketing ploy. Unfortunately, it is also the most overlooked question, even though most social enterprises actually should be able to answer it in a compelling way.

Some examples of important sub-questions:

- What makes your values important to you? Out of all the things you could care about, why these values?
- Why do you care about this specific problem?
- Why do you care about these specific people/ communities?
- Why did you decide on this solution/ way to generate impact?

Not every social enterprise needs to answer each of these in detail – but you do need to answer enough of them to make the rest of your story congruent.



Crafting a Consistent Storytelling Strategy

Providing clear and compelling answers to these three questions is the core of any successful storytelling strategy. Most importantly, the answers need to be congruent, and the overall story you're telling consistent, whether it is on your website, social media, or any other platform. Of course, not every web page or Instagram post can – or should – answer all three questions. But they do need to work together. Every message you send, through text, photos, videos, or other means, has to contribute to the overall story: the story of who you are, what you do, and why you do it.

The obvious question is: How? What makes a story consistent and compelling? Ultimately, the answer depends on the unique aspects of each social enterprise and its story.

Make something remarkable

Your story is the starting point, not the end.

Once you've used your story to get people in the door, the quality of what you're producing is what determines whether they stay.

If you're a café, it's the quality of your coffee.

For a service business, it's the user experience and the results.

Repeat customers are your most valuable ones.

If your customers leave straight away, you create more work for yourself acquiring new ones, which is expensive. If your work is truly great, customers will do the advertising for you.

5. BRANDING BASICS

A brand is the identity of a specific product, service, or business. A brand can take many forms, including a name, sign, symbol, colour combination or slogan. However, brands should be seen as much more than just a logo – **they represent the sum of all valuable qualities of a product/service/company to the consumer.**

Simply put, your brand is your promise to your customer. It tells them what they can expect from your products and services, and it differentiates your offering from your competitors'.

Are you the innovative maverick in your industry? Or the experienced, reliable and steady option? Is your product the high-cost, high-quality option, or the low-cost, bargain option?

REMEMBER: you can't be all things to all people. Who you are should be based to some extent on who your target customers want and need you to be.

Brand Equity

Consistent, strategic branding leads to strong brand equity, which means the **added value** brought to your company's products or services that allows you to charge more for your brand than what identical, unbranded products command. The most obvious example of this is Coke vs. a generic soda. Because Coca-Cola has built a powerful brand equity, it can charge more for its product - and customers will pay that higher price.

The added value of brand equity frequently comes in the form of perceived quality or emotional attachment. For example, *Nike associates its products with star athletes, hoping customers will transfer the emotional attachment they feel for the athlete to the product. For Nike, it's not just the shoe's features that sell the shoe – it's the brand equity as well.*

What is a Brand Promise?

A brand promise is an extension of your company's positioning – the work we did at the beginning of the day. If you think of positioning as the fertile ground that allows a brand to germinate, grow and thrive, the brand promise is a brand's fruit — it's the tangible benefit that makes a product or service desirable.

A few years ago, FedEx declared that it was the only choice “when it absolutely, positively has to get there overnight” — an overt promise that still resonates today.

So why would a business risk everything on a brand promise? After all, wouldn't it be safer to make no promises at all to clients?

In fact, the opportunity cost of hiding in the shadows is enormous. If a business is confident in its abilities and has developed a compelling and consistent customer experience, it can more easily differentiate itself and assume a market leadership position. Clients will choose these businesses more often because they appear to offer more value.



3 Ways to make (and keep) your promise

What promises are you making to your clients? To motivate clients, a brand promise must achieve the following three goals:

1. It must convey a compelling benefit.
2. It must be authentic & credible.
3. It must be kept, every time.

Remember, a promise can define a company in the marketplace. Below are a few examples of companies that create expectations and consistently deliver on them. Can you think of others?

FedEx — *Your package will get there overnight. Guaranteed.*

Apple — *The coolest, easiest-to-use cutting-edge phones, computers and other consumer electronics.*

Woolworths — *to provide an environment that is friendly and warm and where customers can be guaranteed quality.*

Veldskoen — *The most comfortable shoes in your closet after 3 wears.*

The questions involved in developing a brand promise look easier on paper than answering them ever turns out to be in practice. Brand promise development is hard work that generally takes multiple brainstorming sessions, lots of competitor and **market research**, and extensive investigation into the true nature of the corporation. It's exhausting work.

And yet, as with most things that are difficult, it's invaluable. Companies that have clearly defined brand promises and values and attributes have strong frameworks for decision making, and using these frameworks helps develop the brand's strength and worth to the organisation.

So, what is YOUR brand promise? Just a starting point, to be reviewed and fleshed out at a later stage....

5.1 Developing your brand identity

Visual brand identity

A brand's visual identity is the overall look of its communications.

At the core of every brand identity is a logo. So what makes a logo effective?

1. SIMPLE

A simple logo allows for easy recognition and allows the logo to be versatile and memorable. Good logos feature something unique without being overdrawn.



2. MEMORABLE

Following closely behind the principle of simplicity, is that of memorability. An effective logo design should be memorable and this is achieved by having a simple, yet, appropriate logo.



3. TIMELESS

An effective logo should be timeless – that is, it will stand the test of time. Will the logo still be effective in 10, 20, 50 years?



4. **VERSATILE**

Ask yourself; is your logo still effective if:

- Printed in one colour?
- Printed on something the size of a postage stamp?
- Printed on something as large as a billboard?
- Appearing on a PC screen or phone.
- Printed in reverse (ie. light logo on dark background)?

One way around creating a versatile logo is to begin designing in black and white only. This allows you to focus on the concept and shape, rather than the subjective nature of colour. One must also remember printing costs – the more colours used, the more expensive it will be for your business over the long term.

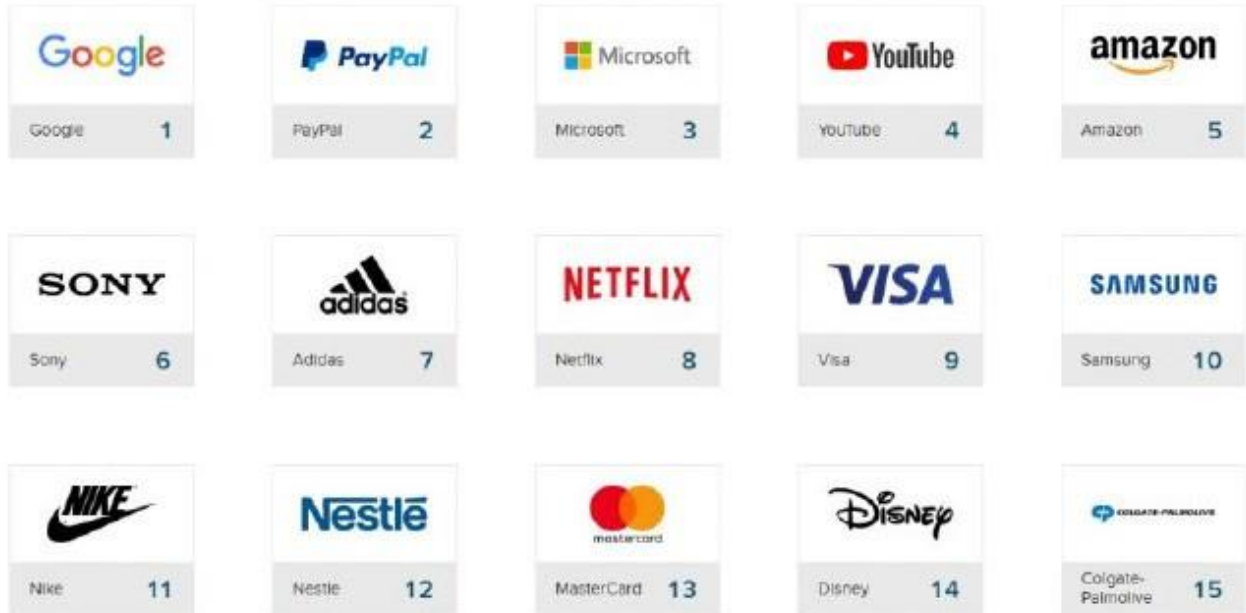


5. **APPROPRIATE**

How you design the logo should be appropriate for its intended target audience and purpose e.g. kids, luxury, innovative, etc.



5.2 World's Most Trusted Brands in 2021



1. Sum up your brand in one word

2. Sum up your brand in a rhyming sentence

3. Sum up your brand in a tweet (140 characters)

6. DIGITAL MARKETING

This chapter will support you in crafting and executing a digital marketing strategy which puts your business' best foot forwards online.

You will find:

- Essential Elements in Marketing in the digital age
- Benefits of Digital Marketing for Small Businesses
- Which digital marketing options or channels best fit your business?
- Five Key Steps to Building your Website
- Do's & Don't of Digital Marketing
- Case Study: Mama Bongi
- Questions to Test your Understanding

6.1 Essential Elements in Marketing in the digital age

Marketing in any form requires:

- Clear business objectives defining what you are hoping to achieve
- A solid understanding of your target audience
- Competitor research and industry insights
- With digital marketing, this is just as important! Below let's discuss how each applies to digital marketing specifically.

6.1.1 Clear Business Objectives

As with all marketing, in digital marketing you have to clarify business objectives and then establish and set goals, ensuring that all marketing activity has a purpose.

Examples of marketing objectives:

- Raise Awareness
- Build brand equity
- Develop customer loyalty
- Leverage customer relationships
- Conversions (e.g. purchase or bookings)

This objective will help to inform which platforms you use, and how. For example – Instagram ads may help spread the word about your business but do little to develop customer loyalty. Email marketing is well suited to leveraging customer relationships (for example by sending weekly or monthly mailers) but not be helpful for raising awareness as the people on your mailing list will already know about your brand!

6.1.2 An Understanding of your Target Audience

It's imperative that you understand the habits and interests of your target audience to create an informed digital marketing strategy.

Bear in mind that customers use social media in different ways, based on their age, access to networks and technology, and interests, amongst many other things. Even when deciding which platforms to use, you would ideally want to base this on the preferred app or apps of your target consumer.

For example, if your target audience is Gen Z, you would likely need to look at platforms like TikTok, Instagram's Reels functionality or Youtube Shorts.

If your ideal audience is professional businesspeople, maybe LinkedIn is a better fit.

Plus, there is likely little point in being overly active on social media if you sell products mainly to ageing people from rural areas, for example.

6.1.3 Competitor and Industry Insights

Your ideal digital presence depends on your business, your competitors, and your industry! You can find some examples of this below.

If you operate in the **tourism industry**, making your business proposition available on websites such as **TripAdvisor, Bookings.com or Airbnb** would be very important.

If you have a **clothing or accessories brand**, you will likely be interested in leveraging the **Shop functionality of Facebook and Instagram**.

Events may be the name of the game and therefore **Facebook's Events** format could help drive RSVPs!

You may be an online educator in which case **Skillshare, Udemy and Youtube** would be well suited to attracting students.

6.2 Benefits of Digital Marketing for Small Businesses

Here are five key benefits of digital marketing for small businesses.

Digital marketing:

1. Connects you with millions of consumers on the internet
2. Saves you money as is typically more cost effective than more traditional means and can deliver higher ROI if you have a marketing funnel which is converting.
3. Enables real-time customer service and one to one conversations at scale.
4. Connects you with the mobile consumer – which is especially important in an attention economy where mobile marketing is imperative to standing out.
5. Helps you to get ahead of your competitors, and can help you compete with large corporations, even with a relatively small budget.

6.3 Which digital marketing options or channels best fit your business?

When choosing a social media or digital marketing channel, keep in mind the product or service you are offering and the available human and financial resources at your disposal. Social media may be largely free, but think about the cost of your time, as well as the fact that algorithms greatly limit the reach of your content.

For example, just because you have 100 likes on Facebook does not mean that 100 people will see your post. Therefore, spending time and energy haphazardly can mean you do not get the results you are looking for.

Determine the most relevant platforms for your business (based on your objectives, target audience, and industry) because usually there is no point in signing up on every social media channel out there, and then build a plan and stay focused. There are pros and cons of each platform so be sure to understand their nuances!

DIGITAL MARKETING PLATFORM CONSIDERATIONS	
Website	A website allows you to appear in search results and is considered an “owned” platform. This is in contrast to social media platforms which are considered “rented” or “bought” – that is, that they could disappear tomorrow – along with all your customers! A website is important in establishing your brand and what it is that you sell, while frequently allowing customers to access crucial information and even allowing them to check out! Whilst a website may seem intimidating, platforms like Wix and Squarespace can help you to DIY and make a website yourself in a short space of time. <i>TOP TIP: If you're selling products that follow trends, you should use Google Trends to watch for declines and discover new trends.</i>
Search Engine Optimization (SEO)	Search Engine Optimization describes the process of making your website easy for search engines to index and serve content to customers searching for what you are selling. This includes ensuring your website is mobile friendly, has plenty keywords pertaining to what you are offering and quick load times to ensure consumers have a great experience on the web. <i>TOP TIP: Best practices specific to your website can be generated using free tools like Google's PageSpeed Insights and SEOSiteCheckUp</i>
Search Marketing	Search Marketing is a further way to ensure your site is shown when customers are searching for products, by paying Google to serve an ad when someone searches for keywords you have bid on. You set the price! But be aware that certain keywords are highly competitive, so trying to outbid your competitors can prove costly. However, the benefit of search marketing is that the person searching already has some sort of intent around the product, making them a more ‘warm lead’. <i>TOP TIP: Google Keyword Planner is a great tool for learning the search volumes of keywords as well as getting new ideas for related keywords. Sign up to Google Ads to access this feature.</i>

Google My Business	Not every business has a website! Some choose to instead use Google My Business which allows you to put pertinent information like location, trading hours and even offers without having to invest the time in building a site. It is also completely FREE! <i>TOP TIP: While Google my Business can be a great stop gap, but as branding opportunities are limited its typically not a long-term replacement. Both should ideally work together in driving traffic to your business.</i>
Facebook	Facebook allows you to target your audience and have your ads reach customers in a cost-efficient way. Setting up a Page for your brand is the best way to get started. It will allow customers to get in touch, review your business and much more. <i>TOP TIP: Facebook has some key features for Pages like Insights and Ads Manager, allowing you to see who is connecting with your brand and targeting other, similar people.</i>
Instagram	Instagram is a platform for sharing images of the work your business does and is also owned by Facebook. From a travel business to a laundromat, Instagram is a good way to reach new and existing clients. Your Instagram account can be linked to your Facebook Business Page, which allows the ads you run on Facebook to appear on Instagram, and the content to be shared across both platforms too! <i>TOP TIP: With newer functionality like IGTV, Reels and Guides – it is constantly re-inventing itself to keep up with its competitors. -Instagram will give preference to its newer formats so leverage these to get better reach!</i>
Twitter	Twitter ads can be pricey but having a Twitter account for your business can be a good idea to keep in touch with customers. It's an easy way for your customers to contact you about your products and services, or for you to get information out to your audience quickly. Twitter is a high frequency platform and allows you to engage in conversations around topics relevant for your brand. <i>TOP TIP: Twitter is a free tool to better understand sentiment, FAQ's, and customer feedback within your industry, and is easily searchable using hashtags!</i>
LinkedIn	LinkedIn is the social media network designed for business networking. But don't write it off as a bland or staid platform! Many businesses leverage the personal branding of their founders, leaders or staff to show off all the facets of their business. <i>TOP TIP: Create a WhatsApp group for your staff and encourage them to share updates on your business from their unique perspectives, humanizing your brand online and using your staff as ambassadors.</i>

TikTok

TikTok rose to fame in 2020. It is an app based around short video formats and is breaking records in terms of just how quickly it entered mainstream culture. Why? Its merging of popular culture, hit music and a fun, collaborative approach to content means it is one for brands to watch! Just like Facebook's promoted posts, it has something called Sparks which helps amplify reach, and also has more expensive ad formats like branded hashtag challenges which some of the world's biggest brands have jumped on.

TOP TIP: TikTok's slogan for businesses is "Make Tiktoks not ads" – make sure that authenticity is the focus of any brand work on Tiktok to ensure it does not feel overly produced like a TV commercial.

YouTube	YouTube is one of the original video apps, but has done a lot of transforming in more recent years. New features like Youtube Shorts mean that it is just as able to compete with short form video apps as what it is housing longer format music videos, documentaries and more. <i>TOP TIP: Use third party tools like TubeBuddy or VidIQ to understand what content is more searchable. Producing "evergreen" content which indexes in search is a reliable to get search traffic to your videos.</i>
Clubhouse	Clubhouse is one of the first audio – only social media networks. While it is not yet mainstream in terms of its usage for brands, it is certainly a platform to be aware of as many thought leaders are engaging in live conversations on the platform, and big platforms sitting up and developing their own versions of audio only experience. <i>TOP TIP: Whilst it might still be in its infancy when it comes to brands, why not follow your mentors or people in your industry on Clubhouse to pick their brains virtually on getting started.</i>
WhatsApp for Business	WhatsApp for Business is designed for small businesses, giving you more functionality than that of 'normal' WhatsApp. This includes catalogue functionality which allows you to show off up to 500 products or services, auto responses and the ability to generate a QR code or short link for customers to start conversations with you. <i>TOP TIP: Not sure if you are going to use WhatsApp for Business? Why not transfer your personal number to WhatsApp for Business to give it a bash, and then transfer it back before deciding whether to get a second SIM card to run WhatsApp for Business on longer term?</i>
Email Marketing	Email marketing allows you to reach your clients using a limited budget and in a professional way. Why? Well, it is convenient, personal, and instant. When setting up an email campaign you can personalise it and make your branding sing in every email. Programmes like MailChimp and Mailblaze provide affordable email marketing options for SMEs. <i>TOP TIP: Take advantage of free tools such as Co-Schedule's Subject Line Tester to test your subject lines. It will help you write better email subject lines that will drive people to actually open your message.</i>
Display Marketing	Display marketing is a kind of paid media format which involves displaying banner ads to customers as they browse websites. Think of all the ads you see when you read the news or check the weather – brands have bid on this inventory and are trying to gather awareness for their brand or service. <i>TOP TIP: While display ads are fantastic for getting millions of eyeballs, consider that the person seeing them is typically on the web page for something else – so your creative truly needs to be thumb stopping!</i>

6.4 Five Key Steps to Building your Website

Although tools like Wix and Squarespace make it easier than ever before to build a website for your business, it can still be an overwhelming exercise. To help you get started, here are five key steps to consider.

FIVE KEY STEPS TO BUILDING YOUR WEBSITE	
BUILD	You have to think about the role your website will play for your customers. When you build your website, its key that you build it with the search engine audience in mind (what will my target audience search for on Google when looking for my kind of products/services, or when trying to solve a problem?). The way you structure your page, the language you use and how you describe what you do has to be the core part of your website.
MARKET	Get the search marketing right at the start! Which types of search engine keywords are your clients using when shopping or looking for information online? Adapt them to your business and make them part of your website. It is often useful to include a blog to create topical pieces of content which will help your target audience and may help them to consider buying from you as opposed to your competitors.
TALK	Build customer relationships. Invest energy in nurturing potential customer relationships, such as forums or Q&A sections on the site. Ensure relevancy in what you say, how you say it and why. Tone of voice is an important indicator of your brand personality so ensure that your copy (text) underscores what your brand is all about.
OBSERVE	Watch your site and your customers. Who they are, what they do, where they go and why they go there? Google Analytics is a very useful tool for this. <i>TOP TIP: Recently Google have launched Google Analytics 4 which means that even if you already had Google Analytics running it may be outdated. Be sure to swap over to this new version of Analytics.</i>
REFINE	Act on what you learn, refine the plan and decide what changes you'll make. • How will you enhance the website? • What is working best? • What are your customers looking for? • What do you need to do to achieve higher conversions? • What caused your customers to respond? And how did the response vary between the different segments of your customer base, the timing of any mailings and offers? • Which data is most useful for your business to track? • Can you select some key performance indicators that will act as a monitoring system for your web marketing? • Do you or your partners need to install additional tracking tools? Invest in your web analytics so you can hear what your customers are really saying. <i>TOP TIP: Remember that digital marketing is an iterative process and therefore you have to revisit your initiatives frequently to unpack what is</i>

	<i>working vs. not.</i>
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6.5 Do's & Don't of Digital Marketing

We have broken down some insights to help ensure you implement best practice from the get-go.

DO'S & DON'TS OF DIGITAL MARKETING	
DO's	DON'Ts
• Develop a social media plan that defines your channel palette (which platforms you intend to use, how frequently you will use them and what success will look like to you). • The key to success in social media marketing is to keep posting fresh, interesting and relevant content. Social media platforms and email marketing campaigns should engage with your customers. Ask them questions, answer their questions and create a sense of community. • Be consistent in showing up – building an audience organically requires an active presence over a long period of time. • Use hashtags. They are a great way to gain more followers and improve engagement. You can add hashtags to your post, story or follow hashtags relevant to your business. • Make your posts valuable, by offering your audience information that is useful to their lives – think tips, tricks and hacks. Remember that this is all part of soft selling and that hard selling on social media is a no-no.	• If you are going to use social media to promote your business, you need to be active on your profiles. Inactive social media profiles are the same as having a website that is horribly out of date or has no information on it. • If you see this channel as merely a way to try and sell or promote yourself, you will not reap the rewards you seek. Instead, aim to build authentic connections over time – which will result in a more loyal customer base. • Don't post content that is 'off brand' – that is, uses colours other than your own, or different fonts. Think of each post as a brand building exercise. A great tool for this is Canva. While the free version is perfectly fine, it may be worth investing in the paid version which allows you to save colour palettes and fonts. • Don't feel that you need to be online 24/7 – use auto responses and schedulers to help you show up even when you don't feel like it! Try out Hootsuite's free plan to get a feel for what they have to offer.

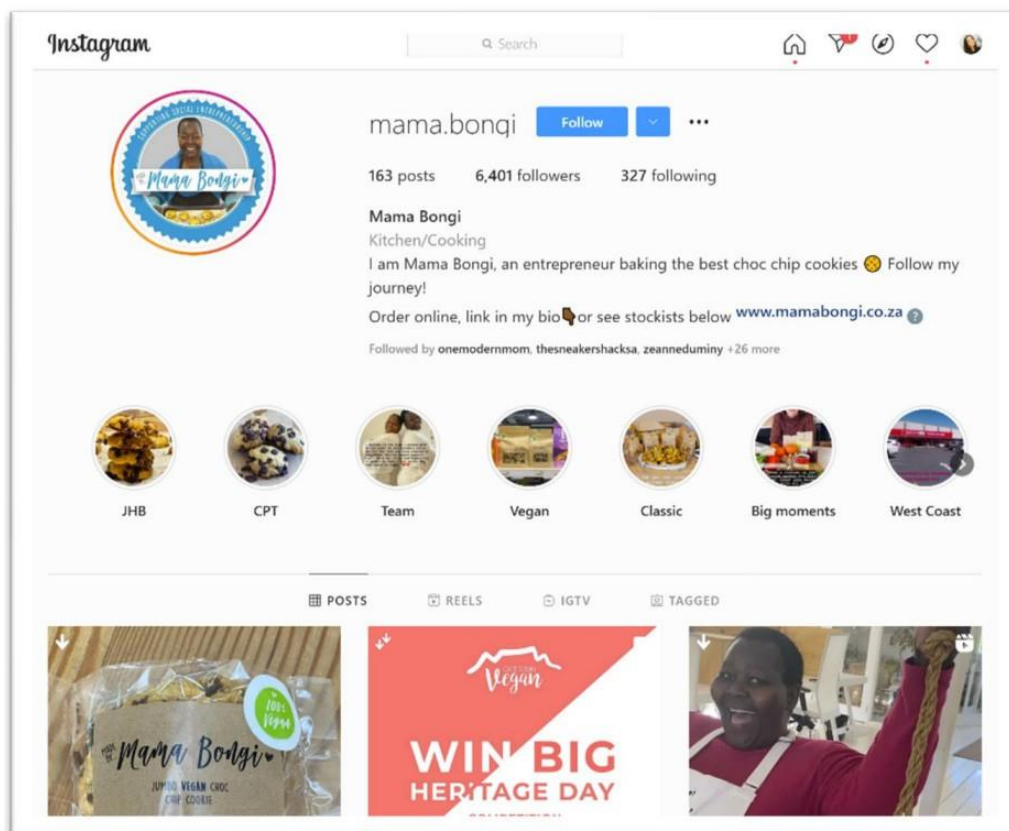
CASE STUDY: MAMA BONGI

What makes brands truly great on social media is that they reflect their business in a holistic and authentic way. They don't just post about their job – they share behind the scenes, live videos of them working and there is always a fun spin on more mundane tasks.

Check out Mama Bongzi's [website](#), [Instagram](#) and [Facebook](#)! She brings her love of baking cookies alive through what she posts. Pay special attention to her Instagram bio –

"I am Mama Bongzi, an entrepreneur baking the best choc chip cookies. Follow my journey! Order online, link in my bio – or see stockists below."

It is succinct and to the point – it tells us what she does and how we can support her! Other things you might wish to include are where you are based, who your customer is and how you deliver your product or service.



She uses Instagram Highlights to keep things organized (JHB, CPT, Team etc) and posts a lot of video content to share more about her business. She also has competitions live on her page to encourage customers to engage with her brand and stand to win incredible prizes. Note too that she has partnered with other local brands in order to get more visibility.

TOP TIP: You can improve the reach of your posts on social media by collaborating with influencers or people within your sector.



6.6 Now it's your turn!

1. Which social media platform(s) are you currently using to market your product/service?

2. Why are they working or suitable for your business

3. Which social media platform(s) do you think is the best to market your product and why?

4. Compose an engaging Tweet that will tell people about the launch of a new product. Remember, you only have 280 characters!

5. Now that you know more about hashtags and why they are so important – compose a post promoting one of your products or your services and use relevant hashtags to gain more followers and improve engagement.

For more on digital marketing go to <https://fetola-mmoho.learnworlds.com/course/social-media>



Sales



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7. SALES: SELLING TO WIN!



In order to survive and progress in a competitive world, we all need to understand selling and art of persuasion. If companies are to compete and win in the 21st Century they will need people who are highly trained with in-depth product knowledge, and who are able to think outside of the box and to recognise new opportunities instantly. And then to know how to turn this into a sale!

If you are going to beat the competition, you will need to be a true sales professional; which is exactly what today's workshop is all about.

This one-day workshop is based on the proven, globally recognised methods of Richard Denny. His best-selling book "Selling to Win" is a highly recommended read for participants.

What you will achieve from today's training?

You will learn techniques that will help you boost your success. More specifically, it will help you:

- Close a lot more deals;
- Master the art of selling;
- Be a true professional; and
- Be recognised by your peers and colleagues as a winner – in more than just sales.

There are two parts to success in sales, namely the art of the sales process and developing your industry & product knowledge. Everyone can master the sales methods and techniques shared with you today, but it's up to you to master your own industry and product knowledge!

How do you feel about sales?

It's probably an understatement to say that not everyone loves sales, and one of the most common complaints we have heard from entrepreneurs is 'I hate selling!' or 'I am an entrepreneur, not a salesman!' So, if you feel like this, you are not alone.

Before we proceed, let's start out with a look at just how comfortable you are with sales and the selling process:

QUESTION	ANSWER			
Rate your feelings about sales (please tick a box)	I totally love sales	Sales are OK	I dislike sales	I am afraid of sales
What do you like/ enjoy most about it?				
What do you dislike about it?				
What are your own strengths as a salesperson?				
And your own weaknesses?				
What is your sales strategy in the business and are sales at a level where they should be?				
Where should they be? What is your sales goal for the next 12 months?				
What do you think needs changing/ improving to achieve this goal?				

8. THE ELEMENTS OF SALES SUCCESS

The beauty of sales is that it is an activity that lends itself well to a simple replicable method. Literally **anyone can sell if they follow the method**, do some training, and remain motivated to succeed.

Think of sales as building a success strategy for your business.

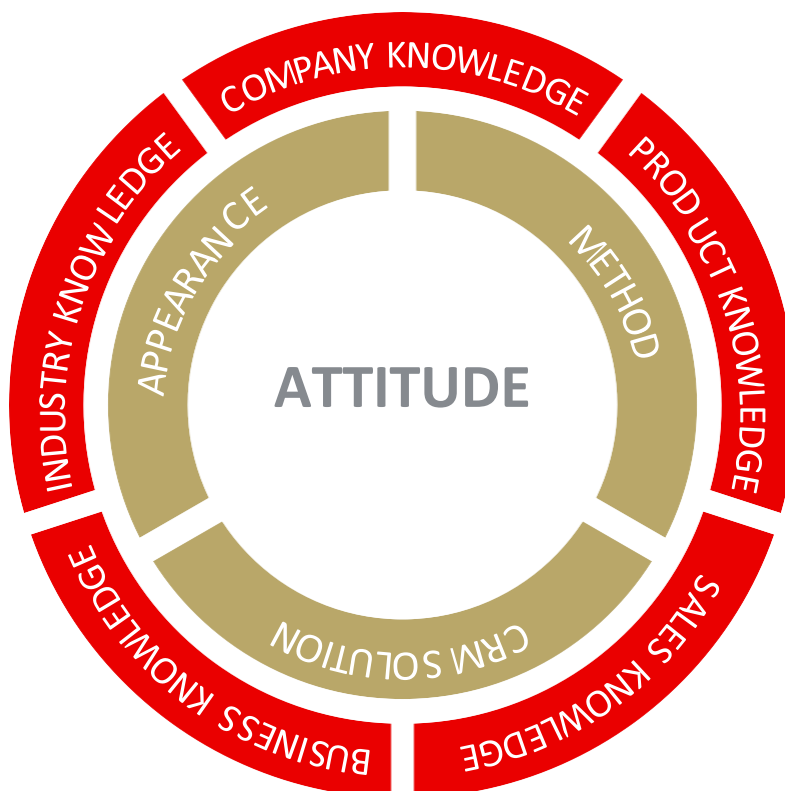
8.1 Planning to win

"Show me a successful person and I will show you a salesperson. The fact is, we are all selling one way or another." - Richard Denny

The task of a salesperson is to make it easy for customers to buy. Sales professionals are there to help customers make the right decisions – for themselves, the customer.

There are many components to being successful at sales, as the diagram below illustrates. Let's share and discuss them.

Figure 1: The Elements of Sales Success



8.2 Cultivating a positive attitude

Let's start at the beginning – the essence of sales success. Your attitude is the rock on which a good sales technique rests. Let's take a moment to unpack what a 'good attitude' is and how we can cultivate it.

Appearance

In sales it is essential to look the part and to dress in a manner that inspires you with confidence and inspires your client with a confidence in you. Your clothes should be appropriate without being over-done and when interacting with clients your grooming should be impeccable. Pay special attention to your shoes – for some reason people often get judged by their shoes!

Look smart but don't break the bank by buying branded clothing you cannot afford. One or two new outfits that make you feel good and look the part are all you need. Develop your own style that allows you to relax in your sales meetings and let your inner abilities shine.

Also pay attention to your sales and marketing materials. These should be crisp, clean and professional. NEVER hand out crumpled business cards or brochures that are outdated and have coffee stains on them....

Preparation

In the same way that you cultivate an outer appearance that is smart, slick, and confident, so too should you cultivate an organisational method that is efficient, effective, and professional.

Start with organising your diary and 'to-do list', making sure to review and refine it daily.

Create and use simple record-keeping systems and insist that all your staff follow the same methodology. This will allow you to track their progress, ensure continuity across the organisation, and keep track of everything that has happened when people leave.

Exercise: List three things you can do to ensure you feel 100% prepared for any sales interaction

- _____
- _____
- _____

Customer relationship management

Every business needs a system to manage customer relationships. In its simplest form, this would take the form of a database of contact names and addresses. In its more complex form, this would include computerised software to track conversations, emails, quotes, sales, trends, and client personal details through a system like Zoho or Access.

A customer relationship management (CRM) system is vital, but the discipline to follow it and maintain regular records is where the magic lies.

Essentially a CRM system is a database of contact names, numbers and client information. The most important thing is that all this information is in one place, is updated and is segmented. Segmentation allows you to communicate with different people in different ways and is essential for bulk emails or text messaging.

The winners' attitude

The most vital ingredient of success is confidence. This takes the form of a deep-down belief that you know you will win, no matter what. It is a truly positive state of mind, heart, and gut that translates into knowing that all is well.

How to be a winner:

- Goal setting: High achievers know what they want in life, turning what they want into goals.
- Planning: Success increases as you become more efficient with your time and resources. Cultivate the habit of daily and weekly planning and a prioritised 'to do' list.
- Self-belief: Work constantly at building your self-belief by educating yourself, practicing and training. Use positive self-talk!
- Be open to constant improvement and see criticism or failure as a valuable opportunity to learn and grow.

Improve your self-belief by constantly improving your skills and refining your goals and dreams.

"The only way to conquer fear is to keep doing the thing you fear to do!"
- Richard Denny

8.3 Building self-confidence

None of us feel great all of the time, and the highs and lows of life are as natural as breathing in and breathing out. Your challenge as a leader and sales professional is to master an ability to moderate these fluctuations and gain a constant state of solid self-confidence.

Five tips to building self-confidence:

1. Get rid of excuses. You can have success or excuses, but not both.
2. Build your self-image. Picture yourself winning and train yourself with positive self-talk.
3. Banish thoughts of failure and only allow yourself to visualise success.
4. Dress up, show up and look up!
5. Keep a record of your successes. Lock it in every time you succeed and praise yourself first for your achievements, before identifying what to improve on.

Cultivating an attitude of confidence starts with the practice of being positive and enthusiastic. When everyone around you is down and the media drowns you in negativity, this requires a conscious effort to focus on what is working, and what potential exists.

Exercise: Building a positive mind-set. List three things that bring you down, and three things that lift you up.

8.4 The five (further) steps to successful sales

Anyone can become a professional salesperson, and everyone can improve their selling skills. The starting point is to identify the five steps that sales professionals need to master. These are:

Business knowledge: Keeping abreast of the business climate in your country is important when meeting with other business leaders. You need to feel confident in discussions about market trends, major events affecting business, politics and other factors affecting business and business confidence. You will get this from reading and listening to a wide range of media to grow a broad set of viewpoints.

Industry knowledge: As a professional salesperson, you must be fully apprised of the industry in which you operate. Read up about changing trends and be aware of your competitors' products, prices and unique selling points. The more you know your industry the better you can respond to your client queries and concerns.

Company knowledge: Your salespeople are your ambassadors. Make sure that they are fully briefed about your business and can converse intelligently about it. Company profiles, values, history, who to contact, and when is important.

Product knowledge: It seems so obvious doesn't it? But many salespersons go out there with a limited understanding of their products. It is essential that your sales team (and you) are 100% confident about your products and services, and are ready to answer any details on technical, marketing, packaging, pricing, and delivery. Product knowledge is an absolute must for all people in sales and is often a weakness when hiring or using contract sales staff.

Sales knowledge: As we will find out today, there are some sales essentials that every salesperson must master. These are simple and easy to implement once you have had some practice and committed the process to memory. Even the most experienced salesperson needs to refresh and refine their skills, and salespeople should ideally go for sales 'tune-up' annually, including continual learning.

Now that we have done some work on ourselves, we are ready to get out there and find some customers!

9. INTERPERSONAL SELLING

Have you heard the phrase “Telling is not selling”? Good salespeople understand that selling is about understanding the customer – asking questions and listening carefully to the answers.

There are some techniques we can master to help us be better salespeople. The most important of these, is learning how to LISTEN.

9.1 Open ended questions

These are questions that do not just have a ‘yes’ or ‘no’ answer but require some more comment. They are very useful in allowing a salesperson to determine the customers’ needs and make suggestions to satisfy those needs.

Examples of open-ended questions in a sales environment could include:

- What is the most important outcome you are looking for in terms of my service or product?
- What timeline do I need to work within?
- Who is the ultimate decision maker in terms of this project?
- Which of my products or services have caught your eye?
- What sort of budget did you have in mind?
- What specific design do you need?
- What size would be preferable?
- What colours would you prefer?

Remember, sales is about asking the right questions, listening to the answers and being guided by the customers responses.

9.2 Active listening

Active listening is a structured form of listening and responding that focuses the attention on the speaker. The listener must take care to attend to the speaker fully, and then repeats, in the listeners own words, what he or she thinks the speaker has said. This enables the speaker to find out whether the listener really understood. If the listener did not, the speaker can explain some more.

Why is it important?

- First, it forces people to listen attentively to others.
- Second, it avoids misunderstandings, as people have to confirm that they do really understand what another person has said.
- Third, it tends to open people up, to get them to say more.

An example of active listening would be to say, "So am I correct in saying that you are looking for a compact home solar system, preferably one that can power your geyser and lights, with a budget of around R3 000?"

Reading the customer

Good salespeople all share a special ability to "read the customer". (Reading the customer means understanding what they want even if they haven't told you!)

It involves looking at their body language, listening to what they say and reading between the lines. For example, if you are showing a customer a range of your products and he says: "My wife really likes eco- friendly products", what is he really saying?

It is surprisingly easy to "read" your customer, once you recognise what to look for.

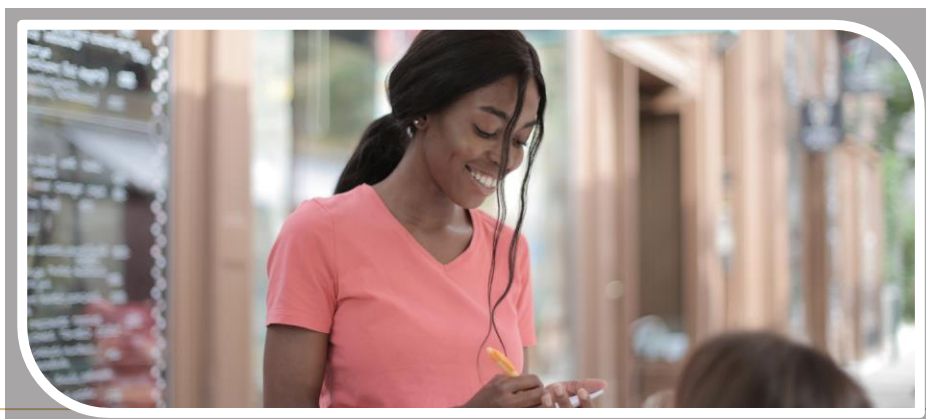
There are four things to watch:

1. Body language: are they constantly touching a certain product or products?
2. Looking: where are they looking, and at what products?
3. Saying: do they mention a certain service or product more than once?
4. Responding: how do they respond or react to your prompts and suggestions?

The customer is then able to either confirm that you have understood them correctly, or else correct anything you may have misunderstood, thus minimising the potential for mistakes and misinterpretations.

List 3 examples of open-ended questions that have relevance to your product or service.

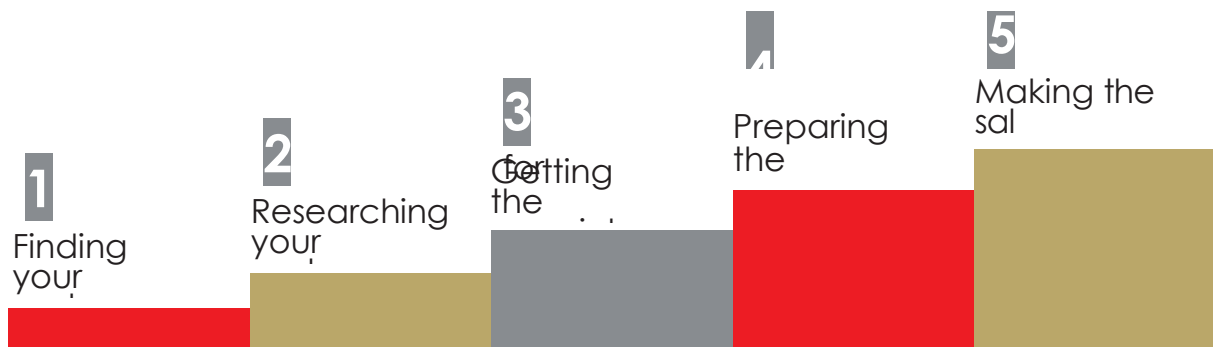
1. _____
2. _____
3. _____



10. THE SALES METHOD

Selling is a five-step activity. Each step is essential to your success and builds on the next stage. If you follow this process you will find that sales become easier and easier. Don't be tempted to skip or re-organise these steps!

1. Find your customer.
2. Research your customer.
3. Get the appointment.
4. Prepare for the sales meeting.
5. Make the sale.



Whilst every business and sales situation is different, it helps to learn a simple method, which can be mastered (and adapted) to your individual circumstance. Let's start



10.1 Finding your customer

The start of the sales process is to identify a customer or 'prospect' to sell to. There are many ways to do this and it's easier than you think. There are two basic types of customers: those people whom you already have a relationship, and those that you are still to meet.

Customers can be found in the following ways:

People with whom you have an existing relationship

1. **Existing customers:** Your existing customers are always the best starting point. They already know, like, and trust you and your products.
2. **Referrals & recommendations:** These make wonderful sales prospects, and the process of referral should be encouraged – by thanking the referee, and by making it easy for a customer to want to recommend you. The best way to do that is to provide exceptional products and memorable customer service.
3. **The "No, not today's":** In your database you will have a list of people you have previously contacted, who said "No, not today". It's time to approach them again. Remember, on average it takes seven contacts with a customer to make a sale.

NB: This is a reminder of the importance of continually collecting and storing the contact information of all people you meet, people who could become your customers – walk-ins included. This database becomes your most valuable tool when looking for new sales.

4. **Past enquiry list:** This includes emails, websites and adverts. People who have contacted you in the past to enquire about your products and services are an excellent source of customers. You may not have sold to them yet, but they have expressed an interest and so are a good prospect for a sale.
5. **Follow old customers** to new positions. Good sales people make a point of developing and maintaining strong interpersonal relationships with their clients. This becomes of great value when the client moves to another company, as they can now become a doorway into a new business. Stay in touch via LinkedIn and/ or regular updates.
6. **Business cards:** That pile of business cards on your desk now becomes a great tool. It's time to convert this into a customer relationship management database, where you can track and manage each contact. Remember when networking that obtaining the other person's card is more valuable than giving them yours for this reason:

New people – those whom you have still to develop a relationship with

7. **Advertising, direct mail, leaflets, social media posts and websites:** These customers will arise as a result of your marketing efforts. A carefully crafted marketing campaign should drive interested people to your website, business premises or to make a call. Your job now is to convert them into customers by selling to them.
8. **Data mining (directories, home sales, job enquiries):** Another proactive way to identify potential customers is to be creative. For example, look through magazines and newspapers, contact property agents, follow job adverts, and keep an eye open for leads as you go about your daily business.
9. **Buy a client List:** If you are starting from zero, or have a huge sales target to meet, you might consider buying a client list from a professional database company. These days with the POPI (Protection of Personal Information) Act one needs to be sure that you are not doing so illegally, and often these lists are out of date and considered 'spam' by the recipients of your call or emails. Make sure you proceed with caution.

10.2 Researching your customer

Once you have identified a potential client, the next step is to find out more about them. This comes in two parts – first, find out or confirm their name and contact information; and second, assess if they qualify for your attention.

Step one to researching a client:

1. Use the internet (e.g., websites, Facebook, LinkedIn) to find out the name and contact information of the position in authority.
2. Call their receptionist to ask for their contact information and any other information about that person that might be useful to you. For example, are they the person who makes the purchasing decisions? When is the best time to contact them? Do they have a secretary/ PA and if so, what is his/her name?
3. Find out if they're the MAN.

Top tips:

Never combine research of the client with the request for a meeting. This comes across as unprofessional and will likely result in you being fobbed off to the secretary/PA. Rather make the research call to gather the information you need, then end the call and prepare yourself properly before calling back.

Who is the MAN?

MAN is an acronym for:

Money – do they have the money/budget? Are they ultimately responsible for spending it? How much do they have to spend and when? In large organisations with annual budgets, it is important to know what this budget cycle is and to tailor your approach accordingly.

Authority – is this person authorised to make the sale and spend the money? Or do they need to get permission from someone higher up in the company? If this is the case, rather seek out that person and sell directly to them. Sales to a person too low on the hierarchy are too easily delayed and deferred and the 'need to consult my boss' becomes a barrier. If you do find yourself confronted with this in the sales meeting, be sure to request that you be the one making the presentation to the boss – as you have the best product knowledge after all.

Need – there is no point in trying to sell your products/services to someone who is not in need of them, so be sure to research if this person is in fact a potential client. For example, there is no point trying to sell baby nappies to a couple without children.

Roleplay: Establishing who the man is

Work in pairs to run through calling and asking for information on the

MAN. Take turns to be the secretary/gatekeeper.

Exercise: List 3 ways to find the MAN for your business.

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

10.3 Getting the appointment

Once you have identified your potential MAN, the purpose of this stage is to create the actual opportunity to sell. Remember that the more appointments you have, the greater your chance of success, so start calling!

Prepare for your call by having all your research in front of you and a clear plan:

1. **Stand up** to make the call. This will give you confidence and help the sound of your voice.
2. **Speak clearly and confidently.** It's also a good idea to smile so that you sound friendly and warm.
3. Ask the secretary if you can **speak to 'Alex'** (as if you have already been introduced), and offer the full name if clarity is needed.
4. Once through to Alex, **introduce yourself very briefly**, by saying your name and company name, then ensure that he/she is the MAN and say you would like 20 minutes of her/his time to meet with her/him, to introduce yourself and your company. Is she/he available on (give two options only) Wednesday at 9am or Friday at 11am?

For example: "Good morning, Alex, my name is Xabiso Nyati and I am CEO of Fraternity Firehoses. I would like 20 minutes of your time to share with you some information on our new high-pressure hosepipes that could be of real interest to you. Are you available on Wednesday at 9 or Friday at 11?"

5. **Thank her/him** for his time, confirm the meeting date/time and say how much you look forward to Friday's meeting.

Roleplay:

Team up into pairs and practice calling to ask the Personal Assistant to the CEO of your dream company if you could have an appointment.

10.4 Preparing for the meeting

Now that you have the appointment, it's important to prepare for this meeting. You may only have one chance to make a good impression, so be sure to get it right.

Preparation will increase both your confidence levels and your success

rate. These nine tips will help:

The first five tips are all about knowledge, and the last four are about actions and attitude

1. **Research** your contact and their company. Make sure you know her/his full name and title and check the pronunciation of it. Use Facebook, LinkedIn and the company website to get as much information on her/ his personal interests, background and experience. This will give you some clues when trying to establish a relationship.
2. **Research** your competitors and the pros and cons of their products/services. If possible, find out who your client already buys from.
3. **Know the industry** – its background, trends and challenges.
4. **Know your product** and the features and benefits it offers, and have a fresh clean product/company profile with you.
5. **Know your pricing**, your costing and your gross margins. This is very important if you are to be able to confidently negotiate a sale. Take a freshly printed, current pricelist with sales terms and conditions.
6. Practise your sales process and **visualise a successful outcome** – know what you want from this meeting.
7. **Dress professionally** and smartly so you look and feel good.
8. Take a pen and **your ORDER BOOK**.
9. **Arrive early** and remain standing when you wait in the reception area – your power is stronger when you stand.



11. MAKING THE SALE

The process of making a sale is largely universal, whether you are selling shoes, cars, carrots or consulting services. Fundamentally, the concept of sales is about one party satisfying a need of another party. Selling is all about satisfying your customer's needs.

The sales cycle diagram below outlines a typical process when selling to customers. Note that the sales process is not linear. It is a cycle. It is your job to ensure that your client will buy again.

The Steps to Making a Sale



Remember too, that making a sale or securing a project is not the finish line: it is the starting line. Successful businesses know that keeping and growing existing customers is integral to their survival. They spend a great deal of time and money on maintaining good customer relations. Some companies even use sophisticated CRM (Customer Relationship Management) software to help them do this.

You may not need this level of technology in your businesses at this stage, but a thorough understanding of the processes involved in sales (as well as a customer focussed attitude) will ensure that you and your business can only go one way – forward!

Let's get started!

11.1 Establish a relationship

Having arrived at your appointment with your prospective client, you need to start building a relationship with them. It's well proven that "we do business with people we know, like and trust" so once you have placed your order book on the desk in front of you, use these few minutes at the start of the meeting to get to know each other and create a rapport. Relax, find a common interest, and **make a friend**.

This is the time to draw on the research that you did on the person and their company and 'connect the dots' between you and them. For example, if she is a golfer and you are too – it's easy! Alternatively looking through her CV you might notice that you share a university, a hometown, or a previous company. You can also use the fail-safe "How is this weather?" as most people will have noticed how good/ bad/hot/cold it is.

So, remember, the process you are following here is to:

- Create a safe space for discussion and sharing of ideas, concerns and information
- Display genuine interest and rapport
- Learn what is important to the MAN
- Build their confidence in you

List 3 methods you use to establish a relationship with a prospective client:

- _____

- _____

- _____

11.2 Understand their needs - need recognition

This is arguably the most important step of the sales process because it allows you to determine the needs of the client. How you can truly be of service and, in fact, IF you can be of service.

A highly effective salesperson sells **solutions that meet the prospect's needs**. To do this you first have to understand what those needs are. The only way to do that is by asking lots of questions. Does a doctor prescribe remedies before a thorough exam? No. Neither should you jump in with solutions and products nor answers until you understand what they want.

Are they the MAN?

Remember to check once more that you are with the MAN.

- Do they have the **money**? Is there a budget, how much is it, and what are the restrictions on spending it?
- Do they have the **authority** to make buying decisions? If not, can you get a meeting with the person who does? *Ideally you should get meetings with the CEO or ultimate decision-maker.*
- Do they have a **need** that matches what you are offering? If not, ask for a referral, make a friend for your network and bid them farewell.

Don't waste time talking to someone who has no money, no authority and no need.

Aim for a 20:80 split of conversation time in the meeting, with you talking for 20%, asking questions and the client talking for 80%, explaining their needs, concerns and challenges. Typically, you should be asking questions that lead or link to the solutions that you offer, for example:

- Do you buy your products throughout the year?
- Do you have specific delivery needs?
- What challenges do you have with your supplier at the moment?
- What concerns would you have if you purchased from me?
- Do you have a budget cycle that I should be aware of?

Asking good questions will help you determine what will best suit the prospects needs and build confidence, trust and help the prospect consider issues they may not have thought of.

Remember that this is the time to:

- Listen, acknowledge and make the client feel good
- Ask questions to clarify and get a better understanding
- Reflect back the conversation to confirm you have understood
- Confirm if they want a solution

Avoiding conflict

There will be times when your opinion differs from your prospective client. Knowing how to overcome this, to suggest different solutions, or to present ideas that the client is not aware of or even resistant to takes skill.

One solution for overcoming this is 'coming alongside' the client.

Using the analogy of a boat, heading directly at an oncoming boat can only result in an unpleasant confrontation, and a collision. For example, if you are of the opinion that the client is wrong, and your solution is right...and you tell them so!

A better solution is to sidle up next to the client by asking them to tell you what they currently do, to explain their thinking and current strategy. Then in an appropriate manner praise them for that. Remember people always prefer to be praised than to be criticised! Now that you are 'alongside them' and have created a safe space where they feel you are 'on board' with their thinking, the next step is to ask them if there are any challenges, problems or concerns with the existing arrangement.

Now they will start to open up, and to share what isn't working so well. You can safely ask questions and gently probe them for more information. This is the gap. The problem that you can solve!

11.3 Formulating a solution

A good salesperson is always looking for a win-win situation. That is one where the client is genuinely satisfied (preferably delighted) with the product and has a price that delivers good value. You, on the other hand, need to make a profit and be in a position to deliver a product of which you are proud.

For this reason, customer-centred companies looking to find solutions for their customers might consider the following approach

- **Figure out the problem you're trying to solve for them**

Make sure you're offering to solve the right problem and not trying to provide a fix for something that isn't a priority in the eyes of your client. In the above section we have discovered this by asking simple questions like 'what's missing from our product or service that would make it better?' This can go a long way towards defining your direction at this stage.

You will have written down all of these needs/problems so that you can confirm your understanding of them and fit a solution to match.

Now is the time to repeat/reflect back to them the problem and confirm this is what they want to solve.

- **Analyse the problem**

Ask how often the problem occurs, how severe it is, what are the causes, and what, if any special circumstances impact it? Another focus should be on the timeframe of the problem. For how long has it been occurring? Has it been getting worse with time and, if not, are there factors that could cause it to do so in the future?

Be sure to assess how important the problem is by asking. For example, don't assume that price is the issue when the client is more concerned by reliability or delivery. In fact, never assume anything; always ask.

- **Offer a solution**

Now that you have a proper understanding of the specific needs and challenges of the client, you can too match this to your offer and present them with a win-win solution.

Consider alternative scenarios to ensure that you offer a solution that is competitive and mutually beneficial. A standard strategy would be to offer up to a maximum of three options: a luxury option (top of the range), a budget option (cheapest), and a middle road solution, which is where most sales occur.

Of course, this depends on your product/service and its match to the client's need. Remember that the fewer choices you give, the easier it is for the client to make up their mind. **Keep it simple!**

11.4 Closing the deal

Closing the deal and concluding the sale is the ultimate goal of your meeting.

This should be easy if you have followed the steps above and if you've built rapport effectively, treated the prospective client with respect, asked for their challenges and concerns, and addressed them in your solution. Closing the deal can be as simple as saying, *"Fantastic! Sign here and we'll ship the order to you by Tuesday."*

On the other hand, if you haven't yet convinced the prospect, closing may be your opportunity to turn them into a customer.

Remember that it is important to ASK for the sale. Don't leave it vague; be clear, confident

and direct. Here are some examples of closing-related approaches:

- The **"Ask for It" close**. "Wonderful, we have agreement. Can I write out a purchase order for you?", or "That's great, how many would you like, and in what colours", or "Super, if you confirm today, we can deliver in seven days".
- The **"Either Or" close**. "Will that be cash or charge?", or "Would you like 50 or 100?".
- However, if the client is still uncertain and you are working your way through some objections, you might need to close using a **"solutions-based" close**:
 - "If I could demonstrate how this solution solves your needs, would you be willing to buy or switch?", etc.
 - "So you like the product, you have a use for it, and it's not too expensive? Wonderful, how much would you like to order?"

Describe the method you prefer to use for **closing the sale**:

11.5 Thank you! Deliver and after-sales

Good after-sales follow-ups will boost customer loyalty and increase repeat business. This involves a prompt and heartfelt “thank you for the order” and follow-up contact to ensure the relationship is solidified. Staying at the forefront of a client's mind requires persistence and should not be confused with being bothersome. It's important to get an agreement on a next step each time contact is made. The pace of follow-up may slow, but it will never end.

Follow-up conversations are best handled by the salesperson that started the relationship as they are best positioned to gauge a client's willingness to reorder or look at new products and services. However, as salespersons can leave (and go on leave) it's important that the company maintains detailed notes on each client. This should be in a centralised company database and not on the individual's computer, phone or memory.

List 3 after-sales services you could offer so as to ensure customer satisfaction & loyalty:

- _____

- _____

- _____

Lastly, and most importantly, if you cannot close the deal then and there, **SET UP THE NEXT MEETING.** Only leave the room once you have a confirmed and agreed a diary meeting for the follow-up.

Why? Setting up the next meeting puts you in control, sets expectations, and means that you never get into the situation where your prospective client can dodge your follow up calls or emails.

Remember after the meeting:

- Do follow up immediately
- Do keep the relationship human/personal and authentic
- Do confirm the next meeting date
- Do agree the process to follow
- Don't forget to set a diary reminder
- Don't go all cool and distant
- Don't take forever to respond
- Don't go silent!

You have managed to secure a 30-minute meeting with your most prized client. Prepare a sales strategy for this meeting that will get you your first order. Consider all the elements shared above to ensure success.

Role-play this as a group.

Roleplay: Making the sale

NOTES:

[illegible]

12. DEALING WITH OBJECTIONS

Getting objections is just part of the sales and negotiation process and should be dealt with as such.

If you have followed the simple steps outlined in the processes above – i.e. qualifying the MAN, asking questions about their need, asking about common challenges, checking budget cycles, and their price expectations – you should have been able to make an offer that matches their needs and simply close the deal.

But if your sales process goes to an objection, here are very simple techniques that will help you.

12.1 An objection is an opportunity to align your needs

Just as we thank customers that bring us negative feedback, we should look at objections as a great way to really get aligned with their need. The way to do that is to ask questions.

Start by asking questions that will identify where you have a mismatch. Typically, you need to run back through your notes on their need and reconfirm these:

“Mr Jones, I understand that you were looking for a solution that was guaranteed, could be delivered in two days and was provided by a local provider. We have met those needs, so what have we missed? What other concerns or challenges do I need to understand?”

12.2 The four most common sales objections and how to handle them

There are four main objections you'll hear when you're trying to make a sale, and they revolve around **budget, authority, need, and timeliness** (also known as BANT). Knowing how to recognise these objections and having a process in place to handle them is key to closing a sale or removing a poor-fit prospect from your sales queue. We're going to walk you through each objection and give you tips for addressing them.

Objection 1: Budget

This is probably the easiest objection to identify: “It's all about the moolah, baby”. Prospects may say things like, “I don't have money for your service”, or “There's no room in the budget for us to buy your product.” They may even ask if you can give them a discount. So when a person brings up the issue of money, how should you respond?

- How to handle the objection

Concerns about the cost of your product can go deeper than the quoted price. It's up to you to figure out what the true reasons are for their indecision. **Dig deeper** to find out why they aren't happy with the price. Is it just shock? Or is it that they don't see the value in your offering for the price that they have to pay? Getting to the root of the objection is key and it will help you choose the right language to use to overcome it.

If it really is just shock, you can explain about all the components that make up your product or service and emphasise how much value they're receiving for the price they are paying. If the prospect isn't convinced of the value, you'll probably want to explain how much he or she could save using your product or service. Both conversations are similar, yet slightly different to better

address the needs of your prospect.

Have a policy never to discount. Discounting reduces the value of your offering and trains the customer to believe that your first price is over-inflated.

It is much better to offer more for the same price, for example: "If you take three I can give you the last one at 50%."

Or simply reduce the total ticket into their budget, for example: "I tell you what, why don't we reduce the size of your order so it fits within your budget?"

Objection 2: Authority

In this objection, prospects may try to pawn the decision off on someone else. This is a very common objection, especially if there are multiple decision-makers within a company. You'll hear, "I have to speak with my boss/CEO/ designer/co-worker/mother about this before deciding," or "My boss/CEO/designer/co-worker/mother says no thank you." So what do you do when you're given the slip because of someone else?

- How to handle the objection

First: if you qualified that you were speaking to the MAN, this objection should not arise. So ask, "I understood from our earlier conversation that you had the authority to make this decision, is there anything that I missed?"

Second: offer to go with the person into that meeting with their superior, after all you know your product better than anyone. "Great! I would love to present to your superior, when and where do you need me?"

Third: validate that the objection makes sense. Again repeat your conversation: "I understood from our conversation that you needed x, y, z and we have met that, is there anything else that I should understand?"

Lastly, if you fail with the above, thank them and set a date and time for the next meeting so you can get feedback.

Objection 3: Need

Especially for complex products and services, this is a prevalent objection that sales representatives will face. You'll recognise this when someone says something like, "You know, we really don't need your product or service", or "Your product is too hard to use, we'll just stick to our old ways of doing things and get by." This is probably the hardest objection to handle since it revolves around the actual product or service you're selling.

- How to handle the objection

As in the above, ideally you should have been checking and confirming the need through the discussion and providing a solution that meets this stated need. But if you find yourself in this position, ask questions:

"Mr Nyathi, I understood that you were looking to replace your existing water hoses and needed one that could be delivered in 14 days. We are able to meet your needs, so what have we missed? What has changed? What other concerns or challenges do I need to understand?"

Like in Objection 2, you'll want to first get to the root of the problem. Do they view your entire product as something worthless, or are there a few features they love? Or, are they just overwhelmed with your service offering? Or, are they just too scared to make a purchase? No matter what their reasoning

is, you need to get to the bottom of it before moving forward.

Their responses can vary greatly depending on what you're offering, but you have two weapons up your sleeve to help address this objection: content and data. Use them carefully in response to the client need.

1. **Happy clients counter-argument:** "Mrs Tawenda would you change your mind if I could share information with you about customers who are happy with our product?", or "Would you like me to share this with your boss/CEO/partner/project manager?". If they agree, go ahead and send/share the case studies.
2. **If your prospect is especially sceptical,** try using some hard data to help convince them. Again, be cautious about how you do this – we don't want the client to feel stupid or overly pressurised.

Let's say you're selling environmental impact assessment services, for example. If the prospect was concerned that these services will not add value to their bottom line, you could pull up some stats from the 2015 Green Report that show that more than half of corporate companies reported positive ROI for their EIA audits in 2015. That data is much more convincing than just "It's the way of the future ... just trust me and give me your credit card."

Lastly - with this objection especially, it's very possible that you find prospects who may not need your product or service at all. Perhaps you both realise that your product doesn't quite meet their needs, or their company goals aren't aligned with what your product or service can solve. In this case, it's time to politely bid farewell. No feelings are hurt here, and, if you remain friendly and polite, no bridges are burnt.

Politely exit the discussion, with a genuine "Thank you for the opportunity to talk" – and perhaps a request for a referral to someone in their network who WOULD be interested.

You now have the chance to focus your time on helping those who are a good fit for your product or service!

Objection 4: Timeliness (Delayed purchase and 'thinking about it' excuses)

Last, but certainly not least, many sales representatives will have prospects procrastinate or put the sales process on hold. They'll say things like, "It's not the right time to make a decision. Please call me in a month or so once our imminent project/hiring plan/budget/etc. is in place." The chances of them actually coming back and purchasing something from you? Slim. So how do you handle this non-committal objection?

- How to handle the objection

Again, this objection can be tricky based on the prospect's real reason for delaying the sales process. How you handle the objection all boils down to their reason for delaying – but you should always remind them of the long-term pay-out if they buy your product or service right now.

1. Increase the urgency: "Buy now, the price is increasing/the stock is low"

For example, you can state real (or not so real) problems with supply, price increases, seasonal specialist, changes in model, etc. to encourage a 'buy now' mentality.

2. Increase the offer "If you sign up before month end I can give you an extra month free".

Once you have double-checked what they like about the product you can give them more than they expected and secure the sale.

3. Use the exclusivity argument "I have a lot of interest from other customers but could offer you exclusivity on this deal – if you confirm within the next 24 hours."

Ultimately, knowing how to address these objections could help you close a sale ... or just disqualify a lead from being a fit for your company. By handling these objections, you'll better understand your prospects' needs - which could help you focus your time on turning the right prospects into new, excited customers.

Exercise: List 4 responses you could employ, to these objections:

- The price is too high

- I need to speak to my manager

- This isn't really what we need

- We will look at it next year

In sales, “no” only means “no for now” “no for now”. So if you come to a hard-stop be sure to retain the relationship, and create an opening for a follow up. Close the meeting in a polite and friendly manner and ask to set an appointment for a date in the future for a review.

With thanks to Ginny Sosesky and
blog.hubspot.com

GETTING TO YES – Tips to close the deal

Whether you're a startup or an established entrepreneur, here are a baker's dozen of our best commandments for sealing the deal.

Ask for the sale! The whole purpose of the discussion/meeting is to sell, so ask for the sale.

Remain seated: The saying goes: present the product, service or idea on your feet, but always negotiate from your seat. Even if your prospect stands up, remain seated. Going from a seating position to standing up suggests something has changed and allows your prospect to exit and end the negotiations.

Always present a proposal in writing: People do not believe what they hear, they believe what they see. Always have a contract available and a writing pad. Anything offered or points of value that are included should be written down to show buyers what they get when they make a decision with you. This can be typed up and sent through in a professional format after the meeting.

Communicate clearly: No one will trust a person who cannot communicate clearly and confidently. Some people practice using recorders and video and then play them back to ensure their communication is coming across the way they intended.

Make eye contact: This is a discipline instilled only through practice, and you can perfect it by recording yourself. If you want to be believed, it is vital to make eye contact with your prospect. It suggests interest in them and confidence in yourself, your products, your services, and in what you are proposing.

Always carry a pen. All agreements require signatures and that requires ink. Keep a pen available at all times. In fact, always have a back-up pen, too.

Use humour: Any humour that can make people feel good, inspired or hopeful is always appropriate during the close. Everyone loves a good story, and people are more likely to make decisions when they are less serious. You will close more deals if you can get your client to lighten up and laugh.

Ask one more time: Figuring out another way to circle back and reposition negotiations after being told "no" ultimately will make you a great closer. It is not rude to persist; it is the sign of success and prosperity. Because you continue to ask in another way for a "yes" after being told "no" does not mean you did not listen. It only means you are more sold on your view than you are on the other's view.

Stay with the buyer: Each time you leave the customer to check on something, it creates doubt and uncertainty in their mind. It can create undue antagonism in the negotiations, lower perceived value, and extend the closing time. But keep in mind, this does not mean there is not an appropriate time to leave a buyer and use an authority for a close, as this can be very powerful as long as it is not overused.

Always treat prospects like buyers: Regardless of the circumstances: no money, no budget, not the decision maker – always treat the prospect like they are a buyer. Always survey the prospect for signs that demonstrate they have bought in the past. The watch, the shirt, the suit, the necklace, the car they drove, the house they live in, the credit card they use, and others. All are evidence that this prospect has actually demonstrated the ability and history of closing. Tell yourself, "Every buyer is a buyer. Treat them as a buyer and they will turn into a buyer."

Ask for what you want: At some stage you simply need to ask for what you want. You may need to employ close-ended questions for this part of the process, such as 'Who shall I make the invoice out to?', or 'If we delivered next week Wednesday would that work for you?'. Other times you will need to be a bit more subtle, but at some stage you are going to have to ask for what you want.

Be positive: No matter how the buyer responds, keep it light and maintain a can-do attitude throughout the negotiations. When you go negative due to the buyer being negative there is only one outcome, and it's not good. Negativity always succumbs to positivity.

Always smile: This is not just about your attitude, but also your physical manifestation. For the next week, practice smiling with everyone in every situation you encounter. Do this until you are able to argue with a smile, disagree with a smile, negotiate, overcome objections and close with a smile. Have you ever noticed that very successful people smile a lot? It is not because they are successful that they are smiling, it's how they got successful. This is a million-dollar tip: Smile

With thanks to Entrepreneur.com

13. FIND YOUR UNIQUE SELLING POINTS

Knowing what differentiates you and your product or service from your competitors in the marketplace is an important part of confident selling. These Unique Selling Points (USPs) are critical to understanding your offer and making others aware of value.

EXERCISE: Determine your USPs:

1. Describe your product or service in one sentence:

2. List the normal features and benefits that you (and your competitors) provide with this product/service:

- ---

- ---

- ---

- ---

- ---

3. Now list the features and benefits that are unique about your product or service – in other words what NO ONE ELSE IS DOING.
Identify any benefits and features that ONLY you do

- ---
- ---
- ---

4. Go back to step 2 and flag anything you do significantly better than anyone else:

5. In step 3 is there anything that your competitors cannot duplicate, reproduce, or copy and add to the list. E.g., Licenced, IP, your own personality:

6. Use all this to create a phrase/s about your unique product or service that are short, clear, and concise. Make it simple to understand by you/your customers. This is your USP!

[illegible]

14. WINNING WITH SALES

14.1 Attributes of successful salespeople

The techniques and methods of sales are teachable to anyone, but there are a few natural skills of great benefit if you want to be successful. Take time to master these!

A good salesperson, whether you are selling cars, cakes or services, needs the following attributes:

1. **Effective communication**

Master the ability to speak clearly and confidently. Sales is all about talking to people and getting them to understand what you are trying to communicate. Don't mumble and avoid talking too fast as many of us do when we get a bit nervous. **Speak clearly and slowly!**

2. **Ability to listen**

A great salesperson knows when to stop talking and listen. They never cut someone off while they are talking, because in doing so, they could fail to hear a key element in identifying what that person's needs might be. Sales is all about understanding and meeting the customer's needs, so active listening is the most important skill in sales. **Learn how to listen!**

3. **Ask great questions**

Ask questions that identify the real need or desire of the buyer. **Ask the right questions!**

4. **Be a problem solver**

Great salespeople are always solving problems. The ability to identify the buyer's problem and offer suggestions to solve the problem through your products or services, generally results in a sale. **Provide solutions to a problem!**

5. **Be organised**

Good salespeople have a keen ability to break things down into smaller steps and organise a plan of action. They know how to analyse what the goal is and in what order the steps need to be in order to reach that goal. **Organise everything!**

6. **Be a self-starter and self-finisher**

A successful salesperson never needs anyone to tell them when it is time to go to work because they know that if they do not work, they will not succeed. They are also very persistent and finish what they start. They achieve their goals, even if they are small ones. **Drive your own goals**

7. **Positive self-image**

A "can-do" attitude is very common among good salespeople. They are confident and do not let difficulties get them down or affect their work. **Stay positive!**

8. **Be well mannered and courteous**

The best salespeople are very well mannered. Good manners are a way of showing respect for others. People are attracted to those that respect them, and mutual respect is fundamental in building lasting relationships with people ... including buyers. This includes punctuality and time-keeping – being late or missing an appointment is an absolute relationship killer in sales. It shows a lack of respect for people's time and is simply not excusable in any shape or form. **Be on time!**

9. **Be naturally persuasive**

Great salespeople are very persuasive. They never give up or give in. They help clients to make a decision, rather than forcing something on him that he does not need. It is all about your sincerity. **Be sincere and believe in your solutions!**

10. **Be a person of integrity**

Honesty in sales is so important. You or the person you are looking to hire is either a person of integrity, or not.

Included in this is being honest enough to say, "No thanks" to an order that has an unattainable deadline, or a contract that you are not currently equipped to execute successfully. A tendency to "over-promise and under-deliver" is one of the major weaknesses in the SME sector, and a reason why many large corporates are nervous about doing business with SMEs. Rather say, "You can have 50% of the order on that date, and the rest two weeks later", if this is possible, than simply accepting an order only to falter when it comes to delivery on time. **Just be honest!**

List 3 attributes of a great salesperson that you struggle with. How will you develop these attributes?

- _____
- _____
- _____

15. APPENDICES

Appendix 1: THE LANGUAGE OF SALE

B2B Sales

B2B is short for “business to business.” It indicates sales made to other businesses, rather than sales to individuals. The latter is referred to as “business to consumer” (B2C) sales.

Conversion Rate

The percentage of people who completed a desired action on a single web page, such as filling out a form. Pages with high conversion rates are performing well, while pages with low conversion rates are performing poorly.

Cross-Selling

When a sales rep has more than one type of product to offer consumers that could be beneficial, and s/he successfully sells a consumer more than one item either at the time of purchase or later on. An example is when Apple sells you an iPhone and then successfully sells you an Apple iPhone case or a pair of Apple headphones. In this case, a sales rep identifies a need the customer has, and fulfils that need by recommending an additional product. (Cross-selling differs from up-selling)

Customer Relationship Management (CRM)

Software that let companies keep track of everything they do with their existing and potential customers. At the simplest level, CRM software lets you keep track of all the contact information for these customers. But CRM systems can do lots of other things, too, like track email, phone calls, faxes, and deals; send personalised emails; schedule appointments; and log every instance of customer service and support. Some systems also incorporate feeds from social media such as Facebook, Twitter, LinkedIn, and others. The goal is to create a system in which sales reps have a lot of information at their fingertips and can quickly pull up everything about a prospect or existing customer.

Direct Selling

Direct selling refers to sales that occur through independent sales representatives, usually not from a store but from the customer's own location.

Forecasting

Estimating future sales performance for a forecast period based on historical data. Forecasted performance can vary widely from actual sales results, but helps sales reps plan their upcoming days, weeks, and months, and helps high-level employees set standards for expenses, profit, and growth.

Lead

A person or company who has shown interest in a product or service in some way, shape, or form. Perhaps they filled out a form, subscribed to a blog, or shared their contact information.

Margin

The difference between a product or service's selling price and the cost of production.

Mark-Up

The amount added to the cost price of goods to cover overhead and profit.

Objection

A prospect's challenge to or rejection of a product or service's benefits, and a natural part of the sales process. Common objections often have to do with budget, authority, need, and timing. How sales reps handle objections plays a big role in determining whether a prospect will buy.

Open-Ended Questions

Open-ended questions are those which require more thought and explanation than a simple yes or no answer. They are very useful in helping sales people understand their customer better, and are a critical skill for all sales people to learn.

Social Selling

When sales reps use social media to interact directly with their prospects. They provide value by answering prospects' questions and offering thoughtful content until the prospect is ready to buy.

Unique Selling Proposition (USP)

A Unique Selling Proposition (USP) is a quality that makes your product or company different and unique.

Up-Selling

When a sales rep sells an existing customer a higher-end version of the product that customer originally bought. For example, if you bought a cell phone plan and a sales rep successfully persuaded you to upgrade to a plan with more minutes or data, then that's an up-sell.

Value Proposition

"Value prop" for short. A benefit of a product or company intended to make it more attractive to potential buyers and differentiate it from competitors.

Appendix 2: THE SALES SITUATION - BE PREPARED!

When going to a sales meeting, or when you are expecting a visit from an interested customer at your premises, it is extremely important that you are properly prepared.

- If you are selling products, you need a **full set of samples**, clearly marked with branding and codes where relevant
- A **pricing structure** that is relevant to the customer you are meeting – wholesale, retail, corporate, etc. If you sell services, a broad indication of your pricing structure is necessary. This should include **sales terms & conditions**.
- **Any marketing materials** – business cards, catalogues, brochures, prospectus, copies of media articles, etc that you want to share with the customer.
- A **pen and paper**. Sounds obvious? I have lost count of the times a potential supplier has asked me to borrow a pen to write down the details of my order. Not a great way to instil confidence!
- If you are hosting the customer, some **tea or coffee, mineral water** and perhaps some fruit or biscuits is always a good idea.
- **Cell phones should be on silent**, and you should only take calls or allow staff to disturb you if it is extremely urgent and after you have asked your guest's permission.

In addition to the physical and environmental preparations, you should also be prepared in terms of information and knowledge, as highlighted below:

Know thy products & services

In order to avoid getting caught out at a sales meeting, it is critical that you have excellent product knowledge and understand the ins and outs of your service offering or your finished products. This could include what is and is not included in the service offer, the raw materials you use, how the end user can display or use your products and any other relevant information that relates to your products, service or offering.

Know thy competitors

Any buyer worth their salt will try and throw a few curve balls to unsettle you or create uncertainty in your mind, in the hope of getting a better deal. Chief amongst these is comparing your offering to other similar products or services available in the market, by saying things like "JBM Consulting does a full green audit for 20% cheaper than you have quoted" or "I can source the same products direct from the East myself at 40% less."

In this instance, it never pays to be defensive, nor will it serve your purpose to speak badly of your competition. Rather, point out the benefits of doing business with you as opposed to your competitors – perhaps your service includes a six-month follow-up, or you are SABS accredited, or maybe you offer a wider range, or can customise products to suit client needs. Maybe you use better quality materials, or perhaps it is your service and reputation that sets you apart.

Know thy customer

In addition to having the necessary sales tools (service overview, price lists, samples, etc.) and a thorough knowledge of your product or service, it is important that you make an effort to do some research to understand your potential customer prior to a sales meeting.

This can take the form of using the internet, or simply speaking to others who may have dealt with them. You may gather information by accessing online databases or the Chamber of Commerce library. The two fundamental questions to ask when researching your potential customer are:

- "What do they need or want?"
- "What can I do to fulfil these needs?"

For example, if your research tells you that the potential customer is a corporate who has a strong affiliation with the Fair Trade or socially conscious movements, you need to ensure that you make them aware of your business ethics and how your organisation meets these criteria.

Similarly, if you discover that the customer has a strong focus on environmentally friendly or recycled products, you can present solutions meet these criteria.

Being armed with information about your customer is also an excellent way of showing that you are someone who is thorough and organised. Statements like "I believe you have 65 shops around the country", or "How is your new head office in Johannesburg?" show very quickly that you have done your homework, and automatically inspire confidence and respect. Take some time out and be prepared when entering into a sales situation – a little preparation can go a long way to creating a great impression!

The tables on page 89 and 91 are designed to assist you in focusing your research, offerings, product knowledge and general preparation for any sales situation you may be faced with. There are two versions, one for a service-based business and one for a product-based business.



Appendix 3: MANAGING RELATIONSHIPS WITH LARGE RETAILERS

Many of us have a dream to become a supplier to a large retailer like Mr Price, Woolworths or Pick n Pay. My response to this is: be careful what you wish for, it may just come true!

Large retail chains have a lot to offer – they order in serious volumes, offer incredible exposure and national distribution. They can also be loyal and repeat customers, especially if the products you make for them sell well.

BUT (Yes, there is a but...) you need to be aware of the following before entering into a deal with a large and established retail chain:

- They have **very demanding systems** for ordering, invoicing, delivery and logistics, and you will be expected to comply like any other supplier.
- **Payment lead times** can vary from 14 days (with a 5% settlement discount) to up to 60 or even 90 days. Can your cash flow sustain you while you wait to be paid an order you delivered over 3 months ago?
- They expect almost **immediate answers to email** and other queries and communications.
- They are very **taxing on your time**. If you are struggling to cope with your existing workload, don't even consider this option unless you can bring in extra resources.
- You will generally need to do all **the packing, packaging and labelling** on the products. This will entail you managing the printing of the bar codes, labels, etc.
- They will expect several **sets of samples** prior to delivery. These are known as red seal or black seal samples and will be used to assess overall quality of the order on delivery.

As you can see from above, managing relationships with large retailers can be a challenge for a small business. However, if you have the systems and the inclination, it can be a very rewarding strategy.

Tips for managing large retail relationships:

- **Befriend the buyer** and nurture this relationship as much as possible.
- **Befriend someone in the accounts department**. This can often be the difference between prompt payment and the poor house!
- **Communicate regularly**. Provide updates on orders, notification of specials or new products, any relevant marketing info or newsletters, and just general contact. Stay top-of-mind!
- **Communicate potential challenges WELL in advance**. Many large retailers have penalties for late delivery, even cancellation in some instances.
- **Stick to the agreed colour, size, shape and quality of the samples** – in many cases even slight deviations will not be tolerated and the order can be cancelled or rejected.
- **Stick to packaging, invoicing, deliveries, etc.** These organisations do not have the time or inclination to have to make allowances for individual suppliers.
- **Manage your cash flow needs** with a good finance system.

List a product or service in your range that you could/already do supply to large-scale retailers or large-scale corporates

- _____

List the resources you believe you would require in order to successfully supply this product or service to large-scale retailers or corporates on an ongoing basis; include things like time, capital, staff resources, etc.

- _____
- _____
- _____

Managing service-based relationships

The service-based business and its sales process

Selling a service generally takes more time and requires you to engage more with potential clients from the outset.

In smaller service-based businesses, potential clients often invest in the salesperson or owner, which makes the client relationship even more important. Your confidence in your company's ability is what will secure contracts and make the client comfortable to choose you as their service provider.

Target market

Most service businesses target their local and regional markets. Some work regionally, while others adopt a national strategy in terms of servicing their target market. This reach depends on available resources and willingness to travel, so set your marketing strategy accordingly using research information to identify the most appropriate target market/s for your service.

Marketing

Service-based businesses focus their marketing efforts on nurturing relationships, creating the perfect customer experience and achieving client satisfaction; as opposed to the core focus of marketing for a product-based enterprise, which is usually to raise brand awareness and product recognition to drive sales.

For example, most small plumbing companies compete with other companies that offer essentially the same services in the same neighbourhoods. In this case, a savvy plumber could advertise faster turnaround times, or offer a guarantee in order to differentiate himself from other plumbers in the area.

Customer satisfaction and retention

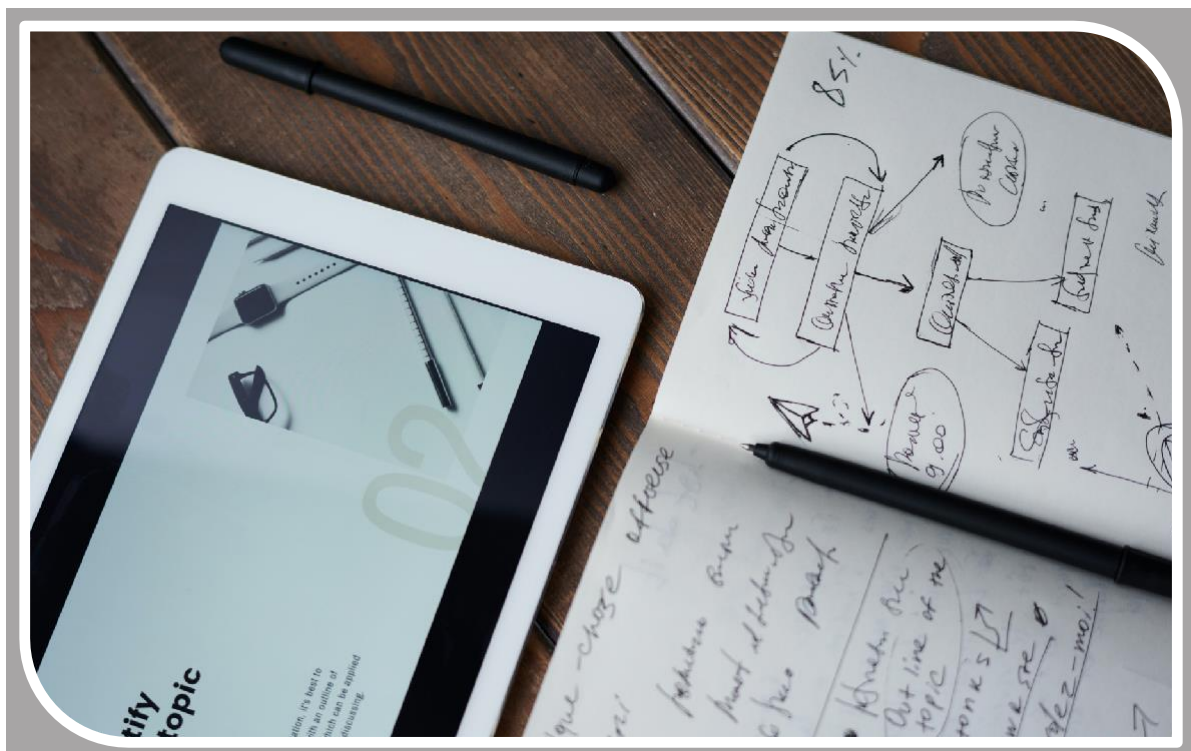
Pay extra attention to after-sales service. This is what will create customer loyalty and word-of-mouth marketing. More importantly, this is the area where you can create differentiation from competitors, and where value creation for the client occurs. Remember, service-based businesses rely quite heavily on a repeat customer base, ideally in long-term contracts or retainers, so the more you can do to create customer loyalty, the better.

Staff and team

Service businesses rely heavily on people/staff to create a positive client experience, which can be risky. This is why you need to put extra effort into staff training, people retention, and standardized systems and methods.

Some further reading:

<http://smallbusiness.chron.com/differences-between-productbased-businesses-servicebased-businesses-23372.html> https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Elevator_pitch



Appendix 4: GUIDE TO ECOMMERCE

Starting an eCommerce business these days is easier than ever – but knowing where to start can be overwhelming! If you are considering setting up an online shop, we are here to help! We have put together key considerations to help you on your way.

First off, to succeed with online selling you will need to have established your brand name and identity as well as what products you would ideally like to sell. It is really worthwhile spending some time on this, as it will be a big factor in your success.

Ideally, you would want to choose a product which is easy to ship, not particularly fragile, non-perishable, and difficult to find in stores. You need to consider market demand, who your target audience is likely to be and how much they may be willing to spend on your product and associated shipping costs.

A tool you may find helpful is Google Trends. This is a Google owned platform which allows you to better understand search interest for a particular date range and country.

Whilst certain products may peak over summer, Christmas or Black Friday – you probably want a business year-round – so consider how sustainable the interest is. Fads might be good to capitalize on for a pop-up shop, but not a sustainable business.

You then would need to establish how you will be delivering your product and understand all the applicable rates and packaging considerations.

It's worth mapping your ideal process end to end, e.g.:

- Where the consumer would find your product
- How they would check out
- What shipping you would charge them
- How you would package the product
- How frequently you would send products (daily, weekly, monthly etc)
- Your own hard costs in terms of manufacturing and shipping
- What sort of minimum order value you need to cover costs and make a profit?
- Will you ship internationally initially or just domestically?
- When the customer would likely receive their product
- How to encourage repeat purchases and word of mouth referrals – online and off!

Once you have established the ideal customer journey, you can work to optimize this

over time. In terms of where a prospective customer may find your products, consider

the following:

- Facebook & Instagram Shop
- Facebook Marketplace
- WhatsApp Catalogue
- YouTube

Once the customer has decided on a product, they then need to check out/pay for it somewhere. If this is offline, consider how. I.e., is it cash on delivery? If you want this to be online, its essential to get set up with a platform which can accept online payments securely. Some options to consider are:

- Shopify
- Woo Commerce
- Wix eCommerce
- Squarespace Commerce
- Etsy
- Yaga

Which platform you end up choosing will depend on a number of factors. If you already have a website, this will be a major consideration. If your website is built on WordPress, then Woo Commerce would be the simplest solution. If it's built on Wix, it probably makes most sense to simply add the store functionality to your site. If you do not yet have anything, you could build both your website and your store using Shopify – which is a very popular all in one solution too!

Bear in mind that each of these platforms will have applicable fees – typically monthly and as a percentage of your turnover. We suggest taking a look at Peach Payments – which integrates across most of the aforementioned platforms – to understand how online payments work. These sorts of costs need to be factored into the price of your products, along with shipping and taxes.

Each platform will have training tutorials to help you get started, so be sure to familiarize yourself with the steps to getting set up and give yourself plenty time. Rome wasn't built in a day!

Consider all the elements you will need to upload to your chosen platform like:

- High quality product photography
- Product descriptions
- Sizing guides if applicable
- Indication of stock levels

Of course, there is no one size fits all approach. Consider other business models, like Creative and Heart. This local company manufactures according to demand (i.e., made to order) and does big pushes for their diaries before each year.

Or consider digital products or services like eBooks or online courses. If you would prefer to look at digital avenues, why not create an eBook in Canva and sell this? You could use similar platforms to those listed above, and also include marketplaces for digital items. Think Skillshare or Udemy for course marketplaces, or Teachable or Kajabi for self-hosting classes.

Once your product is decided upon and your platforms have been set up, you can get creative about content. For example, creating Instagram Reels or YouTube videos to show your products off.

This is an ongoing process and will require new energy and ideas to gain and maintain top of mind awareness in the hearts and minds of your target audience.

It is also a great idea to start building an email database to make launching new products and services easier, with a database of people already interested in your business to communicate with! Take a look at what email functionality your website solution has or look at Shortstack or Mailchimp.

Before you have an email database, its likely you will rely solely on organic and paid social media content – so put your thinking cap on! See what your competitors are doing to promote their products and adapt their strategies to meet your own goals and ambitions. Set up a couple of shoot days to ensure you have dedicated time just to producing high quality content tailored to each platform e.g., vertical format video for Instagram Reels or TikTok, horizontal content for your cover pages or product shots which can be deep etched. Check out Canva's background removal tool for this!

We hope this short guide will help you get started with your business idea and launch it into the stratosphere of eCommerce. Patience plays a big part in getting started, so be sure to allow time for research, trial and error and asking your friends and family for their opinions. It is likely that you may need to pivot your approach and that's just part of the journey! Try not to get discouraged when the going gets tough. You've got this!



Appendix 5: THE SALES STRATEGY OR PLAN

The sales strategy or plan is a tool to give your business greater focus, and improve customer retention, market share, provide more accurate forecasting and improve morale.

A concise, written strategy helps your sales team to know precisely what their aims are and pushes you to make focused objectives. It gives structure to your future plans and forces you to assess your competition, and your competitive advantage. Potential problems are highlighted and your future revenue streams are clearly mapped out. It also allows you to measure performance against targets further down the line.

Step one: Elements of the strategy

Your sales strategy sets clear sales targets and the areas that they will come in. It specifies how you intend to sell your product/service, attract repeat customers and meet sales goals. It sets targets at both team and individual levels. It also specifies at what price you intend to sell to each sales channel. It analyses the strengths and weaknesses of your competitors.

1. Define main products & services
2. Define customer and market segments
3. Identify your USPs
4. Set clear sales targets and Sales method/approach at both team and individual levels
5. Sets pricing for different market segments
6. Analyses competitors and competitive products



Use the sales plan on a page to build this information as you develop your sales strategy.

Step Two: Communicating the strategy

Targets work best when they are quantifiable and measurable. This way it's easy to know if they've been achieved or not. You need to communicate the strategy internally and ensure that the entire company understands what it is and how it fits in with the rest of the business.

1. Make targets quantifiable and clear.
2. Communicate the strategy to the whole business.

Step Three: Monitoring the strategy

Set up a process to gather feedback from your sales team. Agree how often you will review their sales performances, and in what format. Monitor their progress with regular performance appraisals using key performance indicators against the agreed targets. Sales software and CRM packages (Salesforce, Insightly, or Zoho for example) are invaluable for tracking your sales and customer relationships.

1. Set regular feedback times and processes (and stick to them!).
2. Assess performance using meetings, KPIs and software packages.

Take-home summary:

Ten tips to maximise sales success

1. **Set clear, realistic and timebound sales targets.**
2. **Prepare yourself/your team with all the information needed to negotiate.**
3. **Be confident about your prices and margins.**
4. **Identify your USPs and your ideal client.**
5. **Make it simple by following the 5 steps to sales success.**
6. **Maintain a pipeline of potential clients.**
7. **Deal with each of them professionally – one by one.**
8. **No is only no for today.**
9. **Close the deal.**
10. **Continually build the relationship.**

Appendix 6: SALES PLAN ON A PAGE

Company Vision:	Your main target customer	What need do you satisfy?
90 Day Sales target:	Your secondary target customer	What need do you satisfy?
Your Product/Service USP:	Your end-user	What need do you satisfy?
Sales Dept SWOT Strengths:	Opportunities:	
Weaknesses:	Threats:	
Critical success factors: List 3 critical factors in unlocking your sales success?	Sales results – what Sales did you achieve in the last 12 months	What worked/ didn't work?
NOW Actions: What will you do this week to accelerate sales?	Actions: What will you do this quarter to reach your 90 days sales goals?	

Use this template to build the essential information for your sales (and marketing) plan

PRODUCT-BASED BUSINESS	
QUESTION	ANSWER
What are my three main products? Do any of them contain materials that are flammable/dangerous/ requiring special treatment or care?	
How often do I develop/source new products and product ranges? Can I do this if a customer asks me to?	
What is the average price of my products?	
What price points sell the most?	
What products in my range sell the most?	
What products in my range sell the least?	
Who are my main competitors?	
What do they offer that I don't?	
What do I offer that they don't?	
Who are my main customers?	
What are their favourite products? Are there any products I do not currently stock that they would buy from me if I did?	
Are there any other products that complement or work well with my ranges? What are they?	
What is my policy regarding custom made products, or changing my unit size, colours, etc. to satisfy a customer request?	
Why should a potential customer do business with my company?	

SERVICE-BASED BUSINESS	
QUESTION	ANSWER
What are my main service offerings? Are any of them unique to my company? If so, what are these ones?	
How does my sales process work? Is it proactive or reactive? I.e., do I go and look for new business, or does it come to me?	
How often do I develop and add new services to my portfolio, if at all?	
Do I charge per hour, per contract or another way? What is the average price of my services?	
What services that I offer are the most in demand?	
What services that I offer are the least in demand?	
Who are my main competitors?	
What do they offer that I currently do not?	
What do I offer that they do not?	
Who are my main customers?	
What are their core needs as far as my services are concerned?	
Are there any other products or services that can complement or work well with my offering?	
What is my policy regarding customizing my services to meet client needs?	
Why should a potential customer do business with my company?	

Appendix 7: YOUR MARKET ASSESSMENT

You can see from the above that it is important to assess (and continually review) the Market for the goods or services you offer. You need to decide if it makes more sense for you to try and engage DIRECTLY with the end user, or to look for the right channel partners for your product or service. A market assessment involves some research and answers questions such as:

- Is there a market for my offering? Or is it saturated?
- What is the demographic profile, age, gender, buying patterns of my target market?
- Can they afford my product or service?
- What pricing strategy is suited to this market?
- What is the competition and how can I be different from them?
- Do I have the resources, cash, expertise and time to make this work?

You can find information about your identified target markets in many ways:

- **Google** is your friend...
- **Trade Information** - visiting trade shows or by reading print or online publications.
- **Demographic and Economic Data** - information such as age range, income, number of businesses in a geographic area and total sales in your category. This type of information can be found by visiting government portals such as <http://www.statsa.gov.za/> or www.thedti.gov.za.
- **Business Groups** - the local chamber of commerce may have the information you need. You can also consult business support organisations – eg SEDA, NYDA etc
- **Local Competitors:** If you are thinking of starting a local business, research the competition in the area or visit their websites. You can also look for businesses that are for sale & contact the brokers for information, like why they are selling!
- **National Competitors:** Do an online search of businesses in your industry and evaluate what they offer to help fine-tune your idea.
- **Potential Customers:** Conduct focus groups with potential clients and run your ideas past them – these could be family, friends or trusted colleagues.

What all of the above is telling us, is that the more we know about who we are selling to and how they like to buy, the more likely our business is to succeed in the long term.

To understand this in practical terms, we have prepared a simple Market Assessment template below for a typical End User and a typical Channel Partner in your business. Please take some time to complete these templates now:

Using the market assessment form below, do an analysis of the likely END USER/s for the products or services you offer, and fill in the relevant information. If you have more than one product or service, you can do it for each one:

END USER/S PROFILE	CUSTOMER NEEDS	HOW DO THEY BUY?	SALES METHODS
- Age - Gender - Geographic region - Income - Lifestyle - preference (eg sporty, nature lover, fashion conscious)	What main needs does this customer have in terms of your product or service? (eg reliability, cheap price, ease of use, quality, good brand)	Internet, Retail Outlets (if via retail outlets, list some examples of the type of outlet – eg shopping mall, market etc)	What would be the most effective methods of marketing and selling to this target market? Eg social media, advertising, trade shows

Appendix 8: MARKETING PLAN BASICS

Everyone knows you need a business plan, yet many entrepreneurs don't realise a marketing plan is just as vital. A marketing plan focuses on gaining and keeping customers. It's strategic and includes numbers, facts and objectives. It spells out the tools and tactics you'll use to achieve your sales goals. It's your plan of action—what you'll sell, who'll want to buy it and how you will generate leads that result in sales. Unless you're using your marketing plan to help you gain funding, it doesn't have to be lengthy or beautifully written. Use bulleted sections and get right to the point. Here's a closer look at creating a marketing plan:

Step 1: Provide a snapshot of your company's current situation ("situation analysis").

- Define your company and its products or services.
- Show how the benefits you provide set you apart from your competition.
- Provide an overview of your company's strengths, weaknesses, opportunities and threats. Strengths and weaknesses exist within your business, while opportunities and threats are outside factors. For your company's strengths, consider how its products are superior, or if your service is more comprehensive. What gives you a competitive advantage? Weaknesses can be e.g., from operating in a saturated market to lack of experienced staff.
- Describe external opportunities you can capitalise on, such as an expanding market for your product. Also include external threats to your company's ability to gain market share so that succeeding sections of your plan can detail the ways you'll overcome these.

Positioning your product involves two steps: you need to analyse your product's features and decide how they distinguish your product from its competitors; then decide what type of buyer is most likely to purchase your product. What are you selling? Convenience? Quality? Discount pricing? You can't offer it all. Knowing what your customers want helps you decide what to offer.

Step 2: Describe your target audience.

- Develop a one-paragraph profile of your prospective customer. Describe their demographics: age, sex, family composition, earnings, geographic location, and lifestyle. Ask: Are my customers conservative or innovative? Leaders or followers? Timid or aggressive? Traditional or modern? Introverted or extroverted? How often do they purchase what I offer? In what quantity?
- Business-to-business marketers should define the target audience based on their type of business, job title, size of business, geographic location or other characteristics that make them prospects. Define them narrowly, it will be your guide as you plan your media and public relations campaigns.

Step 3: List your marketing goals.

- What do you want your marketing plan to achieve? List measurable goals so that you'll know when you've achieved them.

Step 4: Develop the marketing communications strategies and tactics you'll use.

A good marketing plan targets prospects at all stages of your sales cycle. Many forms of advertising, public relations and direct marketing, are great for reaching cold prospects. Warm prospects – those who've previously been exposed to your marketing message, and perhaps met you personally – will respond best to permission-based email, loyalty programmes and customer appreciation events, for example.

Outline your primary marketing strategies.

- List the tactics you'll use to reach prospects at any point in your sales cycle. For example, you might combine outdoor billboards, print advertising, social media campaigns, and online local searches to reach cold prospects, but use email to contact your warm prospects.
- Find out which media your target audience turns to for information on the type of product or service you sell. Avoid broad-based media – even if it attracts your target audience – if the content isn't relevant. The marketing tactics you choose must reach your prospects when they'll be most receptive to your message.

Step 5: Set your marketing budget.

- Devote a percentage of projected gross sales to your annual marketing budget.
- This may mean using funding, borrowing or self-financing, however, marketing is essential to your success.
- There are many different tactics for reaching out to every audience niche, so there's a mix to fit even the tightest budget.
- After gathering costs for your tactics, you may find you've exceeded your budget. Adjust the tactics until you have a mix that's affordable. The key is to never stop marketing.

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Appendix 9: MARKETING PLAN ON A PAGE

Vision (WHY)	Products & Services (HOW)	Marketing Strategy		Sustainability Impact / Return on Investments Sustainability KPIs/Added Value	
Mission (WHAT)		Marketing Focus 1	Marketing Focus 2	Marketing Focus	
		Unique Value Proposition (UVP)	Focus 1 SMART goals	Focus 2 SMART goals	Focus 3 SMART goals
Target Market – One line summary of your target market					
Target market 1 (Customer persona 1) Problem you solve:	Target market 2 (Customer persona 2) Problem you solve:		Target market 3 (Customer persona 3) Problem you solve:		